Entropy: All Stars Must Fade

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25843468.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

Characters:
Light Hope (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Original Characters, Angella (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Prequel, Tragedy, Romance, Comedy, War, Betrayal, Spoilers, Humor, Angst, Colonization, Psychological Drama, Anxiety

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of The Story of Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

Stats:
Published: 2020-08-11 Completed: 2020-08-30 Words: 19,668 Chapters: 20/20

Entropy: All Stars Must Fade

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25843468.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

Characters:
Light Hope (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Original Characters, Angella (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Prequel, Tragedy, Romance, Comedy, War, Betrayal, Spoilers, Humor, Angst, Colonization, Psychological Drama, Anxiety

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of The Story of Mara, She-Ra of Etheria

Stats:
Published: 2020-08-11 Completed: 2020-08-30 Words: 19,668
Chapters: 20/20

Entropy: All Stars Must Fade

by Tempest_Wind

Summary

Mara’s hopes, her dreams, her promise led her on the path to becoming Etheria’s First Champion. Her courage paved the way for Adora and her friends to change the world. Her sacrifice made their victory tangible. This is her story.

Part 1 of this series focuses on Mara's arc as she takes on the mantle of She-Ra and begins her mission of balancing Etheria.

This is a prequel story revolving around Mara, the Grayskull Squadron, the origins of the First Ones. This will contain spoilers for the first four seasons of She-Ra. Chapters include links to research done on the original He-Man and She-Ra series, and clarification on aspects I made up.

Threshold

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“How do I look?” Mara asked and gave an awkward twirl alone in the sleeping quarters.

The ship’s AI responded with an analytical tone. “You are wearing the traditional robes of the Champion chosen to wield the Sword of Protection.”

“I know that, Light Hope,” Mara insisted. “I was asking you how it looks.” She tried adjusting one of the ill-fitting sections of the multi-layered cloth.

Light Hope was silent a moment to process the request. “Each Champion must wear the traditional Eternian garments and pass each assigned obstacle in order to wield the Sword of Protection,” the AI answered automatically.

“That’s not what I-- ugh,” she gave a sigh as a smile slipped out. “It’s ok. I was asking your opinion.”

Light Hope beeped twice and Mara imagined the AI’s invisible face squinting at her. “I am unable to answer your query.”

“I know,” Mara said with a gentle chuckle. “Once you’re uploaded into Crystal Castle, maybe the magic of Etheria can help you stretch your programming boundaries a little.” She grinned at the thought. “I’d love to hear your opinions on everything in Etheria. It’s supposed to be the most magical place in the galaxy, at least that’s what I’ve heard. If magic can make anything happen, then the possibilities really are endless.”

Light Hope processed her words for several long seconds. Mara understood that she needed prompting in the form of questions.

“Don’t you think that’s exciting?” Mara asked, shrugging her arms to hug herself as she nervously bit her lip.

“When you have become a Champion, the Grayskull squadron and myself will relocate permanently to Etheria,” Light Hope said simply.

Mara grunted and flopped back on her bed. “Fiiiine, you win,” she said.

Lying on her back, Mara traced her fingers up the wall of the ship’s hull, soaking in the cold contact she felt from the touch, as though this was Light Hope’s skin.

“You’ve always been part of my life, growing up on these ships,” Mara said, her voice timid. “You’ve seen me flunk tests before.”

The ship hummed through space, but did not respond.

“Do you really think I can do it? Do you think I can become She-Ra?” Pain etched its way across her face as her hand stilled, resting against the cold metal.

Light Hope beeped once. Silence fell over them and Mara felt her eyes well with tears as fear gripped her insides.

“You have been training to become the Champion for two years,” Light Hope said at length. “You have given every indication of aptitude in regards to intelligence, performance, and creativity. Your rate of failure is far below previous Champions.”

Mara sat up, thrusting herself upright and narrowly avoiding hitting her head on the top bunk, before she began pacing and fidgeting with the robes.

“But what if… what if I fail? What if I’m not good enough?” Mara asked, trying to fight down the nerves that ate at her stomach.

“Statistically speaking, that is highly unlikely,” Light Hope offered.

Mara yanked a pillow off a nearby bed and covered her face with it as she fretted.

“However, even if you do fail, it is likely that you would receive additional training in order to pass the test with a higher success rate,” Light Hope said as a means of consoling her.

Mara’s words were muffled by her pillow.

“Query not recognized,” Light Hope stated.

Mara slung the pillow off and tried again. “You don’t think they’d give up on me?” she asked, lip trembling.

“That would be a waste of resources and time,” Light Hope replied.

Mara groaned. “Thanks for the pep talk,” she muttered.

The comm panel on the wall gave its signature whistle. There was a momentary crackle before Serenia’s voice came through.

“Mara, we’ve reached Etherian orbit,” Serenia said. “Estimated time of arrival is fifteen minutes. Prepare to disembark.”

“Understood,” Mara called back.

Serenia’s tone turned friendly. “How’re you holding up?” she asked, her voice tense with sympathy.

“Barely holding it together,” Mara admitted.

“Goooood luck out there.”

“Thanks.”

Chapter End Notes

Author’s notes:

Both Mara and Adam (from He-Man) are ancient Hebrew names. As a Jew myself, I had some hesitations about using Hebrew naming conventions for villainous characters since we are so often depicted as insidious characters in entertainment. Therefore, I decided to only name the Grayskull squadron Hebrew names, and that the rest of the First Ones would be named following other conventions laid out in the series.

Grayskull Squadron OCs:
Lev (m)
Nessa (f)
Gideon (m)
Shay (enby)

Trepidation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara felt Serenia's hand on her shoulder, giving her one last reassuring squeeze before she walked down the ramp towards the lone scientist. The grass felt like velvet beneath her boots and the winds smelled of strange perfume around the intimidating obelisk that was Crystal Castle. But Mara could not focus on the unique sights, as she was too busy obsessing over the thin strings keeping her together.

"Hi Mara. Very exciting day. I'm Dr. Modulok," the scientist introduced himself. A winged robot sat on his shoulder, its single red eye staring her down.

Mara's lip curled as nerves ate away at her composure. "Wh-where is everyone? The Council?" she asked.

"They're waiting at the end of your challenge," he said, positively beaming at her. "It's up to you to figure out every task ahead: I'm just going to point you to the starting line."

"I'll be doing this without guidance, unobserved?" The thought was equally as horrifying as it was relieving. No one would have to see how many times she messed up, but if she went missing on the course, it would take ages to find her.

"Nooo, oh, gosh, no," Dr. Modulok said with a laugh. "This camera will be following you the whole time. It's a K.O.W.L. system, pretty state of the art if I do speak for myself, or at least my inventions. It's designed for recording and sharing live to comm devices while on, er, unsteady terrain."

Mara stared into the machine's red eye, now aware that dozens, maybe hundreds of people were watching her right at this minute. It blinked at her and she stiffened, fingers going numb and tingly.

“Now are you ready for your test, Champion?” he asked, leading her beyond the grounds of the castle

“P-please don’t call me Champion yet,” she whispered, but he didn’t hear her. They wound their way along a trail carved through woods that were equally as enchanting and fantastical as they were unsettling and unfamiliar.

Each strange new noise sounded like laughter or distant shrieking. Each shadow seemed to shift into countless shapes before growing too large. A rustling came from directly beside them and Mara jumped before a small, fuzzy creature hopped out of a nearby bush. It blinked four sets of eyes at her and showed long teeth, but chirped as though curious. Mara froze where she stood and the creature darted into the underbrush.

Dr. Modulok chuckled and pulled aside a branch that was in their way. “Etheria’s not like the fleet you grew up on,” he said.

“I’ve never seen anything like this,” she said, finally catching up to him. “This goes beyond my wildest dreams. Life on a ship is so predictable, orderly, immaculate. Etheria is wild, uncontrolled, unstructured.”

“That’s why you took the mission? Tired of the regimented life?” he asked with a smile. “Needed a change?”

“Maybe,” she said with a laugh but it didn’t feel right. “I’ve always had an active imagination. I used to imagine faces on AIs and scenarios I’d play out where I had to save the day. I used to pretend I was a hero. I guess I never grew out of that,” she admitted with a blush.

“But Etheria?” she went on. “Everything I heard about Etheria went beyond my wildest imagination. It didn’t seem real. It still doesn’t feel real. It's a little scary, not to understand something. So I needed to see for myself what it’s truly like out here.”

The scientist’s smirk slipped towards something genuine. “That’s… a beautiful dream, Mara,” he said.

“What about your reason?” she asked.

“Oh… mine is something like that,” he said, but she had the feeling he wasn’t conveying the whole truth. “Only I’m not as good with words as you are, so… ditto.”

“Ditto,” she echoed back with a chuckle, relieved to laugh despite the pressure. As they exited the woods, a mountain took up the vision of the clearing before them.

“Aaaand this is where I depart,” Dr. Modulok said. “Good luck and may the Primogen* Council smile upon you.”

“W-wait, what?” she demanded, but he was already making his way back up the path, his comm device in hand, with Mara’s shocked expression on full display. K.O.W.L. fluttered in her face and she tried to swat it away before stopping herself.

“You can’t be serious! What am I supposed to do?” she called, but the formerly helpful scientist was disappearing into the shadows of the forest.

Staring at the mountain before her, Mara felt her adrenaline switch to panic.

Chapter End Notes

Author’s Notes:
The *Primogen Council is the name I’ve chosen for what the First Ones call their decision-making body located on Etheria. It is an indirect reference to Primus, the world that the version of Mara from “He-Man” is from.

The word Primogen shares its roots with two interesting words: “primogenitor” meaning an ancestor or earliest ancestor of people; and “primogenity” meaning the right of the firstborn to the inheritance of their parents (usually an estate or kingdom). Please also note its totally accidental similarity with Horde Prime’s name, indicating that the Primogen Council is not as trustworthy as it first appears.

**Modulok was an Etherian scientist before he become a villain in the original He-Man series. His real name was Galen Nycroft, but since his villain name is what he's better known for, I stuck with that. Here's a link: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Modulok.

*** Kowl was one of many anthropomorphic characters in the original She-Ra series, and was one of the most grating. https://he-man.fandom.com/wiki/Kowl

Test

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Okay… alright… this is…" Mara tried to coach her abundant energy away from anxiety, towards something more productive. She paced along the bottom of the mountainside, trying to gauge the expansiveness of it. K.O.W.L. fluttered nearby, always within distracting range of her.

"Ok, so if I go back into the forest, I can braid vines together to make a rope," she said aloud. "And, uh… and a big stone I can tie to it. Toss it up there…"

It wasn't a good plan, but it gave her cold comfort to have a plan. She turned to make her way back to the woods when she saw something glistening near the entrance to the forest.

Tucked away from the path sat a shining grappling hook, with a fair amount of rope nearby.

"Ohhhh, I can do this…" she murmured to herself aloud as she rolled up the abundant sleeves of her robes. She tied the rope to the grappling hook using a secured knot, and propelled the hook up the mountain side. It fell back once, twice, three times, and Mara felt her patience slip.

"Remember: grappling hooks are moody little things," her trainer, Dree Elle, warned Mara as she stared down the false rock wall in the rec room. "But it's better than nothing. You don't know what tasks lie ahead, so I want you as prepared as possible."*

"How many times do I have to throw it up there?" Mara asked, her voice tense as she held back her exhaustion after a day of practice climbing with additional drills.

"It doesn't matter how many times you throw it up there, as long as the last time is secure," Mara repeated Dree Elle's words to herself. Concentrating, she tossed the grappling hook one more time and felt it snag at the top. She tugged hard on it, and it didn't budge.

"Ready K.O.W.L.?" she asked, turning to the camera. It hovered several feet above as if encouraging her.

Wrapping the excess rope around her hips and thighs, Mara created a loop harness. With the ropes gathered in one hand to tighten the slack, she guided herself using her free hand and her feet found purchase to climb. She relied on the steadiness of fissures for footholds, her fingers seeking a grip in the crags of the rocks as she kept an even pace: step, lift, search.

Stone scraped at her skin and clothing, while pebbles and dirt fell from the rock wall in unpredictable ways. Sweat stung her eyes and blurred her vision, but she kept her pace steady. She felt pressure around her head that became a distracting kind of pain, until her ears finally popped with relief. This was nothing like the manufactured cliff face on the ship back home.

Sooner than expected, she reached a plateau. Wiping the sweat from her eyes and loosening the rope from around herself, Mara took in the sight of the cave carved out of nature. It consisted of three decorated walls slanted towards a staircase that led steeply downwards. The way the stalactites and stalagmites formed around the entrance to the stairwell, they looked like teeth of a great beast.

Hanging from the wall was an armory of giant weapons, the shield standing as tall as a person. But as Mara approached the sword, briefly wondering if this was the fated Sword of Protection, she felt her stomach drop to her feet. An enormous stone ball surrounded by metal spikes fell from the ceiling and, slowly at first, began rolling towards her.

Mara darted towards the staircase, but stopped short as she realized the spiked boulder was picking up speed. For a moment, she looked to the sword. If this was the Sword of Protection, she could save herself.

It was too much of a risk. Instead, she grabbed the enormous shield hanging beside it and held it aloft as though it might defend her against the spikes. After a second's reconsideration, she threw it face-down into the staircase before leaping onto it. It slipped beneath her and she lost all balance, finding herself on her back, in the shield, halfway up the side of the wall and accelerating at blinding speed down the spiraling stairwell.

Her back and tailbone aching, Mara gripped the edges of the shield as she tried to figure out a way to steer this ridiculous mode of transportation. But as she looked back to see how far the spiked boulder was, she saw the fluttering K.O.W.L. struggling to catch up. The boulder was gaining on the little robot.

"K.O.W.L., hang on!" she shouted. Loosening the long, decorative sash from her robes, Mara tied a knot at the end and threw it back towards the little robot, accidentally hitting it in the face.

"Sorry!" she uttered, horrified, until two claw-like pincers emerged from the machine's underbelly and gripped the cloth. Mara tugged on it, fighting the air pressure that came with such speed, and accidentally spinning the shield she lay on.

Despite the total loss of control of her single means of transportation, Mara kept her focus on K.O.W.L., pulling it towards her until she could clutch it under an arm.

"Okayokayokayokay," she panted as she flattened herself to the shield. She tried to reassess the situation now that the robot was recovered, but panic was the first sense to set in, followed quickly by dizziness. Spinning was causing the shield to slow its descent, allowing the spiked boulder to gain on them.

Grabbing an edge of the shield, she tried leaning her weight towards one end to throw the spin off of its cycle. Shifting from side-to-side counter to the spinning movement, she soon gained some control, but the shield was still slowing down.

At this speed, she felt every bump of the staircase beneath them, and watched helplessly as the boulder caught up.

K.O.W.L. began beeping frantically from where it was pinned to Mara's torso. She looked ahead and saw light before a narrow passage signified the sudden end of the stairwell. There was no way to slow down in time.

Chapter End Notes

Author's Notes:
Mara's challenges are based off of Adora's challenge in the original She-Ra episode "The Stone in the Sword." You can watch it here: https://youtu.be/oYUKvHeQA6E.

Research for rock climbing came from here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yoe_iL3NPOA and https://www.rei.com/learn/expert-advice/rock-climbing-glossary.html.

*Dree Elle was a character who showed up in the original He-Man and She-Ra series. I used naming conventions from the show as a callback.

**Does anybody want to guess what K.O.W.L. stands for?

Turmoil

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara tensed her body as she saw the doorway rapidly approaching. She shifted to unsteady feet as she felt the shield impact the frame. She dove through the doorway, landing hard on her shoulder and tumbling along the stone and dirt floor of the cavern.

Using the last of her effort, she curled into a ball as the spiked boulder met a sudden end at the cavern's opening, crushing the discarded shield beneath it. The echo of the crash rebounded across the multicolored crystals that lined the far walls of the room, the sound only disrupted by the drip of water far below. For a moment, Mara dared to think she could catch her breath.

But the boulder's crash caused reverberations throughout the cavern and soon crystalline stalactites fell around her, breaking into thousands of sharp pieces where they landed. Throwing herself to her feet and wheeling her arms to keep steady, Mara ran down the thin pathway, stopping short as the stone floor came to a sudden end.

Thin towers of rock stood before her, each more than her body length apart, and slanted at the top. If she took a running start….

But as she tried to rush her calculations, she heard the distinct screech of crystal meeting metal. Mara spotted K.O.W.L. crushed beneath the broken pieces of a stalactite.

"Nononononono," she gasped, rushing towards it as rocks began falling in earnest. She scooped up the little robot who blinked and whirred at her pitifully, the light of its recording eye fading in and out. Shards of the crystalline deposits and rubble from the rocks smashed against her legs and arms as she tried to cover her head

with an abundant sleeve, cradling K.O.W.L. to her chest as she ran towards the end of the path.

Without a chance to calculate the distance, Mara leapt across the expanse to the rock pillar before her. Though her landing was right, she didn't anticipate the slick surface, and skidded off of it with a shriek.

She clung to the wall of the rock pillar with bleeding fingertips, trembling from strain and exhaustion. She wanted to curse, to shout, to announce her surrender, but all that came from her throat was a wretched sob that echoed back to her through the cavern. The test was a failure: the recording device was struggling to stay cognizant, and likely was unable to send a signal to the council. Mara was too injured and winded to carry on.

Mara pressed her forehead against the cool stone as hot tears streamed down her face. There were many things in life that scared her, but mourning the loss of herself was a new experience. She was going to die in the middle of nowhere, alone, and no one would ever find her.

"I can't do this," Mara said from the floor of the rec room. The staff she used for sparring lay a dozen feet away. Every muscle in her body was screaming.

Dree Elle stood over her, her staff poised as if to deal a finishing blow. She quirked an eyebrow at Mara before offering her a hand to stand. Mara raised a limp hand simply to push the offering away.

"That doesn't sound like Champion-talk to me," Dree Elle said.

"I… don't think I'm cut out for this," Mara said. "I'm not the strongest, or the cleverest, or the fastest. I'm not even brave."

Dree Elle sat down beside her. "Bravery isn't the absence of fear," she said and Mara perked at the words. "It's doing the courageous thing even though you're afraid. That's true bravery."*

Mara reluctantly sat up, her head heavy with those words. "I feel like I'm scared most of the time," she admitted. "Even over silly things."

"But look what you're doing right now: training for one of the hardest tests in Eternia," Dree Elle pointed out. "You're a courageous person, Mara."

"I don't feel courageous," Mara admitted.

"Nobody does," Dree Elle said. "The difference between a brave person and a regretful person is how far they're willing to go. Never stop moving forward."

Beeping issued from around her stomach area. There, nestled close for protection, sat K.O.W.L., blinking at her and moving its appendages weakly.

"You're right," she whispered to the robot. "It's not ending here. Not today. Hold tight onto my robes -- we're getting out of here."

K.O.W.L. beeped and clung to Mara. With exhausted arms, she shinnied her way up the rock pillar. When she made it to the top, she crouched down to leap across to the next pillar. Of course, the top of it was just out of reach, and so she scrambled up the side of it again.

With each pillar she leapt across, her body screamed with fatigue and ache, and her arms and legs trembled from stress, threatening to give out at any moment.

"We're getting out of here," she kept saying aloud as she tasted sweat and blood in her mouth. She leapt and slid across the final of six pillars, which began to crumble beneath her. Stones dropped silently before hitting the water far below.

Before her sat another cavern pathway, completely cloaked in fire. The pillar beneath her slid and crumbled and Mara understood that she had no other option.

Unable to get a firm footing, she leapt across the last of the chasm, wrapping her body around K.O.W.L. to shield it from the fire as she dove through the flaming entrance, landing hard on slick marble.

Too-bright lights shone down on her. She panted, rubbing at her eyes as a thunderous noise arose around her. It took her several moments to realize it was clapping. Blinking against the brightness, she saw more than a dozen robed figures standing in a semi-circle around her in a pristine room.

Chapter End Notes

Mara's challenges are based off of Adora's challenge in the original She-Ra episode "The Stone in the Sword." You can watch it here: https://youtu.be/oYUKvHeQA6E. I added Ninja Warrior-style flair to the cavern because I'm a monster.

*It's important to note that the quote "Courage is not the absence of fear" came from Nelson Mandela.

Triumph

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara couldn't catch her breath, her ears were ringing, and every inch of her body was either numb or stinging. Trembling, she moved to stand on unsteady legs and bowed to the Council.

"Congratulations, Mara," the Speaker of the Primogen Council said, her voice filling the room.

"Your wisdom and determination helped you to climb Skydancer Mountain," the Speaker went on. "Your cleverness and creativity led you to use the shield to out-maneuver the spiked ball in the Neverending Stairwell of the Jaws of Darkness. Your swiftness had you escape the cave-in at the Rainbow Grotto, and your compassion drove you to rescue the robot K.O.W.L. when it was damaged. Your fortitude and perseverance helped you climb the rock pillars of the Forbidden Corner.

"Finally, your bravery and willingness to self-sacrifice led you through the illusory Cavern of Fire. Are these not the qualities of a Champion?"

The rest of the Primogen Council murmured in agreement.

Mara felt like she might pass out, or throw up. The strings barely holding her together were frayed. She kept silently wishing she didn't do anything embarrassing in front of the Council.

The Speaker moved her hands and produced the Sword of Protection, its golden hilt and blue stone glittering in the too-bright lights.

"Mara, you have been chosen as the next Champion to carry the name She-Ra," the Speaker said. "Are you prepared to be the new Champion of Etheria?"

Mara's blood ran hot through her veins. She clutched K.O.W.L. tightly to herself as she stared down the sword she'd only ever dreamed of.

"Yes," her voice came out higher-pitched than she would have liked.

"Then take this sword, raise it, and speak your truth as the Champion of Etheria."

Mara grasped the hilt with a shaking hand. It felt heavier than she expected, more full and real than she anticipated. She lifted the sword to the air and tried to remember the call she had been trained to say.

Honor? Honor something? For the honor of Eternia?

She couldn't remember. She was too exhausted. The entire Primogen Council was staring her down. Truth, they wanted a truth, wanted *her* truth.

"For the Honor…" she began, leaning into what her heart told her to say, "of Grayskull!"

Light and magic weaved its way through her, pushing and pulling the very fabric of her being. She felt herself stretch with the essence of it as it warped her and cleared her body of every bruise, break and cut. Sweet-smelling air filled her lungs as she felt power form in the pit of her stomach.

A noise came from around her and she blinked new eyes open to the sight of councilmembers laughing into their hands.

"'Honor of Grayskull?' Well, that's a rather unique statement," the Speaker admitted.

Mara's face reddened in response. "S-sorry…"

"But if your squadron is your source of power, then so shall it be," the Speaker went on. "Congratulations to Etheria's Champion,

She-Ra.”

The Council collected themselves and applauded. They parted like a wave, and there stood Dr. Modulok, with his hand outstretched and a grin on his face.

“Congratulations, Mara,” he told her.

She, confused by the gesture, looked between him and the sword. He shook his head and pointed to the robot she was cradling in her arm.

“O-oh…”

She felt the power of She-Ra slip away back into her sword, as Dr. Modulok took K.O.W.L., leaving Mara with an overwhelming sense of vacancy. The scientist led her through the forest, giving her a series of instructions and though her wounds were healed, her head couldn’t seem to take in any new information.

She was She-Ra. This was real. This wasn’t a fantasy or a stress dream. She passed the test, and didn’t die or give up. She outsmarted jaws or something like that. Each of the challenges felt like they happened to someone else.

Mara tuned back in when she heard the scientist mention “Light Hope.”

“Sorry, what?” she asked.

“Black box,” he repeated and she was even more lost. “I’ll need you to get Light Hope’s black box from the ship, so we can transfer it to Crystal Castle.”

She stared at him in confusion.

“Crystal Castle, where you’re being stationed,” he said, his tone sharp.

“Right! Yes! Sorry,” Mara admitted. “I-it’s been a day…”

He was all smiles once again. “I know, it was so great to watch.”

That statement gave her a powerful sense of unease.

They arrived at the clearing, with the ship’s ramp already at ground-level and Mara's entire team waiting impatiently for her on the grass. Dr. Modulok peeled away, headed straight for Crystal Castle.

Mara felt Serenia’s gentle hug before she even caught sight of her. Then, towering Gideon swept them both up into his arms.

“Hey, let me in there!” Nessa insisted, squeezing into the hug.

Lev sat in his hover scooter nearby, waiting for the team to make space for him. At Mara’s invitation, he wobbled onto his forearm crutches and leaned his weight against everyone.

Shay, not one for physical contact, found Mara’s hand in the fray and gave her a fist bump with a wink and a friendly, “Nicely done.”

Tears slid down her cheeks as Mara laughed and held tight to her team.

“Don’t you start crying,” Serenia warned her as tears pearled in the corners of her eyes. “When you start crying, I start crying, and that’s not fair.”

Gideon was already sobbing, tears dripping into his bright red beard. “We’re just so proud of you,” he whimpered.

“Oh, jeeze, Gid, Serenia pull yourselves together,” Nessa insisted. “Mara’s the only one allowed to cry right now, after what she went through.” Fighting back emotion, Nessa went on. “We really thought we were going to lose you.”

“Wait, you guys saw all of that?” Mara asked, eyes wide.

“The stream didn’t get interrupted, even during the cave-in,” Gideon said.

“Then you saw everything?” Mara’s voice was so quiet.

“Everything,” Serenia insisted with a war of emotions moving across her face.

“Wait, everything?” Mara’s voice came out in a deadpan.

Shay raised an eyebrow and smirked. “Eeeeeeverything.”

“Oh nooooo,” Mara whined into her hands as she covered her face. “Then you heard me say ‘For the Honor of Grayskull’?”

Her team broke into laughter, and she received shoulder slaps and head pats in response.

“Ohhhh this is so embarrassing,” she whimpered.

“Nahhhh, we know you love us,” Serenia insisted, resting her chin on Mara’s shoulder.

“Oh, hey, where’s the sword?” Lev spoke up.

Mara raised her wrist to show the golden gauntlet. “The sword bends and reshapes according to my will, or something like that,” she said. “They went over it in training, but honestly I don’t remember how it works.” She shifted it back to sword form and Lev held up a finger to balance the blade end.

“Nice engravings. I’m going to have to examine this,” Lev said, his eyebrows wiggling.

“*Hot*,” Shay commented.

“Oh, hush,” Lev snapped with a smirk.

“Do whatever you like with it, as long as you DON’T take it apart,” Mara said. “But first, I’m going to need Light Hope’s black box.”

“I gotchu. Follow me,” Lev said and directed his scooter back towards the ramp of the ship. Mara followed after, as the arms of her teammates slung themselves over her shoulders and Shay walked a cursory two steps behind.

Chapter End Notes

The next few chapters focus more on characterization and Mara's relationships with the cast (including and especially Light Hope).

Tech

The little box-shaped crystal looked so small and fragile as Mara clutched it to her chest.

Dr. Modulok took Light Hope's black box from Mara's faintly trembling hands. Mara clung to the box for a second too long before letting him take it.

"This won't hurt her, will it?" Mara asked, hovering nearby and trying to read the screens over his shoulder.

He scoffed and pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose. "AI can't feel pain, Mara," he reminded her

"I know, but--" Mara began.

"Uploading her to the tech we've installed in this base is essentially giving her access to a wealth of information and abilities she never had before," the doctor went on, meeting Mara's eyes. "We're giving Light Hope the freedom to do things and go places she never could as a simple ship AI. This is a good thing."

"This is a good thing," she repeated, forcing herself to take a deep breath. She winced with a sigh. "Sorry, I didn't mean to give you a hard time."

Dr. Modulok put a calming hand on her shoulder. "Trust me, I know how attached people get to their AI," he said and she felt her face heat up in a blush. "They become members of your family. You know, like a pet."

Mara's entire body tensed as she tried to force out a nod. The idea of Light Hope as some kind of pet turned her stomach, but she didn't want to embarrass herself in front of the scientist by arguing with him.

“S-sure,” she stuttered, momentarily grateful that Light Hope couldn’t hear her lying.

He held the black box out to her. “In that case, do you want to do the honors?” he asked, and she took it without a second thought. “Insert the box into this slot here. You should hear a click.”

She gingerly pressed the box into the slot, well aware that any slight damage could permanently impact the function of the most steady presence in her life. The glowing slot turned green as she felt the slight click. Her hands rushed away from the hardware, scared that she might damage it, as she watched the system absorb the black box.

Crossing her arms, she started rubbing them frantically as her gaze darted around the room. Dr. Modulok didn’t look towards her as he read her the status aloud.

“The Crystal Castle System is extracting and reading the Light Hope files,” he told her. A small whine came from the back of Mara’s throat. “The system is going to start generating a holographic interface. Quick! Go to the center of the room!”

Mara rushed to the center of the room as she watched a small blue light struggle to form before her.

“Do you see it?” Dr. Modulok asked, a tone of playfulness in his voice as he smiled.

“I-I definitely see something,” Mara called back. The little blue wisp flickered and swayed. Crouching down, she let her fingers move through it as though stirring smoke from a pot.

“That’s good,” the doctor called back. “That means it’s working.”

The blue lights shifted to purple, then white, fading out to black for a moment before blinking back in as blue.

“Come on, Hope,” Mara whispered to it. “You can do it. I’m here.”

Though Mara knew that technology functioned off of math and not hopes and dreams, she kept whispering words of encouragement to the little blue wisp that soon formed into a ball, before it shot into the air seven feet above.

"Here we go!" Dr. Modulok said and typed code into his keypad as though finishing a symphony on a piano.

In a shimmer of color, every crystal in the room began to glow as Eternian symbols projected into a vaguely humanoid shape, filling out with purples, blues and whites. Each piece of code, each word. knitted to each other, building a body clad in long robes with purple skin and trimmed blue hair.

Glowing blue eyes blinked open as the figure met Mara's gaze.

"Hello, I am Light Hope," came that familiar voice through the mouth of the woman before her.

Mara forgot how to breathe. Air refused to come as she stared at the face, and into the gaze, of her lifelong companion.

"My function is currently at 10%," Light Hope informed her.

"You're beautiful," Mara whispered, finally catching her breath.

"Is she like what you imagined?" Dr. Modulok called over his shoulder, his back to them as he continued inputting code.

Mara reached towards Light Hope's face, her hand hovering by the AI's cheek before her fingers accidentally moved through it.

"Oh, s-sorry…" Mara murmured.

"I do not have a corporeal form," Light Hope said, eyebrows pinching in momentary confusion.

Mara's heart was pounding in her chest. This was surreal. She tried to laugh, but the sound was tight. "I know. I-I forgot," she admitted.

“Ooooookay, this is all looking good,” Dr. Modulok said as he approached them. “The database has integrated with the AI’s operating system. It’s going to take a few hours before she’s fully operational, and the rest of the day until she’s integrated with all the systems on Etheria, but she can answer simple queries until then.”

Mara nodded, but could not focus on anything other than the holographic figure before her.

“If you run into any problems, reach out on my comm,” he said.

There came an immediate crash from down the hall. Mara tore herself away to run towards the sound.

“GIDEON! You can’t just leave your stuffed animals lying around,” came Nessa’s furious tone from the crystalline floor she recently became acquainted with. “Owww…”

“Whoops, that one got away from me,” Gideon said with a nervous laugh as he set down his own box to help her up.

Mara knelt down to help gather the contents of Nessa’s spilled box

“How many of those things do you need, anyway? I counted at least ten so far,” Nessa insisted.

“Sleeping on a pile of stuffed animals is one of life’s little treasures,” Gideon assured her as Mara handed him the toy that had caused this situation.

“Careful not to leave them in the path of Lev’s chair,” Mara said.

“Mara!” came Serenia’s indignant tone from the living quarters. “Are we just letting Shay and Lev take the room with the biggest bed?”

Mara laughed as she traded looks with Gideon and Nessa. “Duty calls,” she said with a shrug.

Trauma

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara stared at the far wall, where the Sword of Protection rested. Its blue stone glittered in the stream of moonlight that came through the narrow window above. Mara turned onto her back, staring at the lines of the ceiling before casting her gaze to the sleeping Serenia beside her. Serenia lay with her back to Mara, gentle snores escaping her lips, unaware of the other woman's movements.

Taking a deep breath, Mara watched the ceiling as her mind raced. When she tried to close her eyes, there she was, clinging to the rock tower with bleeding fingertips, mourning her certain, untimely demise.

This time, she felt her fingers slip. Air swept through her outstretched hand as her body fell, ice-cold water enveloping her, entering her mouth, constricting her lungs.

Mara snapped her eyes open with a start. Part of her wanted to reach for Serenia's hand, knowing that was what the other woman would have wanted. But she couldn't bring herself to wake her.

Gathering her sword, she walked past the rooms of her sleeping teammates. She heard Gideon's snoring before she saw the door was open. Curiosity getting the better of her, she peeked in to see him sprawled out on top of a mountain of plush animals. He looked comfortable. Maybe he had the right idea.

Exiting the barracks to the main hall, Mara made her way to the center of Crystal Castle. Inside was dark, save for the glow of functioning tech, the wires and lines shaped into words that connected together in ways that seemed nonsensical. The sigil for "conduit" sat connected to the word "princess," and "magic" was connected at the base to "energy" and "heart." Mara figured Dr.

Modulok probably had a little fun designing the wiring of this place.

There was no sign of Light Hope. Anxiety reared within Mara as she fought back fear to remind herself that maybe the AI needed downtime to reboot. Despite her logical side telling her to go back to bed, she wound up calling out the hologram's name.

"Hope? Light Hope, are you here?" she asked, her voice echoing back to her in the barren chamber.

The hologram blinked into existence. "It is extremely late, Mara," Light Hope informed her.

Mara sighed. "I couldn't sleep," she said, taking a seat on the floor. "Everything keeps running through my head. I can't believe all of that happened in a day -- happened today. It doesn't feel real, but… I also can't stop thinking about it."

Light Hope hovered near her, watching Mara with her head tilted to the side. The AI was so expressive in this form.

"You will be receiving further details of your mission starting tomorrow," Light Hope said. "You need to rest."

"I-I know I should…" Mara began. But then her voice grew small and timid, like a child's. "But I thought… maybe you'd like to see my sword?" She let its blade glint in the light of the technology around her.

Mara's chest ached as she watched Light Hope's facial expression change to one of curiosity.

"That is the Sword of Protection," Light Hope said simply. "It is given to the one who carries the mantle of the Champion of Etheria." Though she spoke from a place of logic, she blinked at the sword as if she did not recognize it.

Mara lifted the sword higher for the AI to examine.

“How does it make you feel?” Mara whispered, taking in every shift in Light Hope’s expression.

“Feel…?” Light Hope repeated, her voice distant. She seemed on the verge of understanding something that went beyond logic. “I…”

There came a monstrously loud yawn before Serenia staggered into the room in slippered feet. She regarded the two with a barely-open eye before plopping herself down on the floor behind Mara, her head and back resting against the other woman’s.

“Oh, no, did I wake you?” Mara asked before receiving the full weight of the other woman with an unsteady “oomf.”

“Yeah, but it’s ok,” Serenia said. “I figured you were introducing your new Sword Wife to your Robot Wife.”

Mara flushed beet-red and avoided Light Hope’s gaze. “Serenia, shut up,” she hissed between gritted teeth as the other woman yawned around a chuckle.

“I am confused by Serenia’s terminology,” Light Hope said. “Mara, you are unmarried.”

“Y-yeah, Serenia was just teasing,” Mara insisted, her cheeks fading to pink as she tried and failed to maintain eye contact with the confused AI who kept looking to her for answers.

“I’m offended,” Serenia said. “How dare you say that about your Cuddle Wife?”

“*Cuddle Wife!*” Mara whimpered with laughter, covering her mouth and shaking with amusement.

“Yeah, I don’t do any of that gross relationship stuff,” Serenia said. “None of those mushy ‘I love yous’ and kissing or whatever. But when you’re feeling stressed out, you come to your Cuddle Wife for a cuddle.”*

Mara was grinning despite herself as she leaned her head back against the other woman's. "But I do love you, platonically."

"Gross. Never say that again," Serenia said in response as they both giggled, drunk off the lateness of the hour.

They both flopped back onto the floor, staring up at the ceiling from opposite directions, Mara's sword resting on the floor beside her.

"So what's with the insomnia?" Serenia asked.

"Does it really surprise you?" Mara asked.

"Not really, no," Serenia admitted. "I was just hoping you were finally done stressing out about the test."

"I guess some of it got to me, you know?" Mara admitted. "I got all the way out there, and then I almost gave up. I thought I was done for, honestly."

"But you didn't, did you? You didn't give up," Serenia said.

"I almost did," Mara insisted. "It makes me worried. What if I'm not the kind of leader who can follow through? What if I give up when things get tough?"

"Hmmm," Serenia sighed. "A question for the sages…"

Mara elbowed her in the side and got a shriek in response. "I'm serious," Mara insisted. "I want to make sure I'm the best leader I can be. I'm just… I know I'm not as strong as I need to be."

"Then that's something you'll have to prove to yourself," Serenia said simply.

Mara sat up and hugged her own knees, struggling with the barrage of thoughts running through her mind.

"Help me out here, Light Hope," Serenia insisted as she sat up.

Light Hope stood over the pair, watching them in silence as she took in the request.

“Mara was chosen as the Champion of Etheria,” Light Hope said. “Mara completed her challenge and the Primogen Council chose her to take on this mantle. The Council does not make mistakes.”

Mara sighed against her knees. “I guess you’re right,” she admitted. She forced a smile for the AI. “Thank you, Hope.”

Serenia stood and dusted herself off. “I’m going back to bed.” She offered a hand to the other woman.

“No thanks,” Mara said with that same reassuring, fake smile. “I think I’ll stay here for the night.”

“Suit yourself,” Serenia said, concern crossing her face before she smiled back in surrender. “Look after her, Light Hope.” With that, she padded out of the room towards the sleeping quarters.

Chapter End Notes

*With this fic, I hope to explore the kinds of emotional intimacy that aren't widely explored within our society. While it definitely seems like a bait-and-switch to have Mara sharing a bed with Serenia in the beginning, I hope the way I presented this makes it clear that Serenia supports Mara’s feelings towards Light Hope, even if she doesn’t understand them.

Serenia is aromantic and asexual, and is in a platonic partnership with Mara. Think of it like the next level of friendship, but it doesn’t go the route of romance or “like a sister.” On the surface, it resembles a coupling, but the feelings at the root of it are strictly platonic. This is in contrast to the behaviors of Adora and Catra in the first episode of the series, to show that these kinds of things can look similar, but have a different basis.

Truancy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“You’re sending her out there, ALONE? Absolutely not,” Serenia said, arms crossed and tapping her foot. The Grayskull Squadron was gathered in the main room of Crystal Castle for a debriefing that was rapidly devolving into a debate.

Light Hope blinked at her. “You are not the commanding officer, Serenia,” she informed her.

“I am when Mara’s not around,” Serenia snapped. “And I don’t care -- she just completed her Champion Challenge on her own, and you saw what that did to her.”

“Serenia, stop it,” Nessa hissed as she watched Mara recoil at her words.

“She doesn’t mean it like that,” Gideon said, giving Mara’s arm a reassuring squeeze. “She means we work better as a team -- we always have.”

“The Champion of Etheria is the only one authorized to receive details on the mission,” Light Hope said, looking between each member of the squadron. “If you go against these orders, you will be taken off the project.”

“That is SO--” Serenia was ready to fight.

“It’s ok,” Mara’s voice was tight and whisper-soft, but it cut through the argument. She hugged her own arms and willed herself to stop shaking. “I’ll go to the coordinates and receive my next set of orders. Whatever information I’m allowed to share, I’ll give you all the details.”

She met Serenia's gaze and refused to look away. "Please, this is how it must be done," Mara murmured.

Serenia hesitated, before shrugging in surrender. "I just don't understand why everything's being treated like a big secret." But she left her argument at that.

Lev offered Mara a half-hearted smile in consolation. "Shay and I finished building an access point in the ship so you'll have uninterrupted communication with Light Hope," he informed Mara. "All the data crystals you're going to need are loaded, though I still don't know what some of them do. If you let me take a look at them...."

Mara's smile was warm as she listened. "Thank you, Lev," she said. "I think the more we prove our worth, the more information we'll get. We just need to trust in the system, and in each other."

"Easier said than done," Shay muttered as there came a clatter from the kitchen.

"What's happening in here?" Nessa could be heard shouting.

"LUNCH," Serenia snapped. "If I'm not good for anything else, I may as well make meals."

"How did you already burn it? You've been in here for a minute!"

Mara tried to hold back the simultaneous urge to laugh and cry as she watched her two teammates grimace. "Guess I'm leaving this in your capable hands." Lev and Shay traded looks and shook their heads as Mara made her way to the ship, her golden gauntlet glistening in the moonlight.

The ramp closed itself behind her. Taking the captain's seat, Mara watched the ship rise into the air. Nails digging faintly into the chair, she took in a shaking breath and felt herself tremble against the urge to cry. She gave a start when Light Hope flickered into existence before her.

“I did not mean to startle you,” Light Hope said.

“It’s ok,” Mara said, covering her pain with a smile as she watched the hologram. “I think everyone’s on edge right now. I wish I knew how to ease their worries, but I’d be lying if I said I wasn’t scared too.”

“Your mission is of the utmost importance,” Light Hope reminded her. “The coordinates have been given to the ship’s autopilot. We will be arriving at the Temple of Champions within ten minutes.”

Mara nodded, following along. “And the data crystals?”

“You will use those to establish the access point within the temple,” Light Hope explained. “By enabling the network, I will download the instructions for your mission.”

“By integrating with the network, will that affect your operating system in any way?” Mara asked, her throat tight.

Light Hope analyzed for a brief moment. “Yes. The greater knowledge will upgrade my systems, and provide me with access to the technology developed on Etheria.”

“Another upgrade... so soon?" Mara asked, biting her lip.

“My programming will be influenced by the magic of Etheria,” Light Hope explained.

“Do you… want that?” she asked.

“Want…? What I… want…?” Light Hope repeated. “Query not recognized.”

“It *is* recognized,” Mara insisted, meeting the other woman’s eyes as she moved to stand. “You know what it means to want something, Hope.”

Light Hope’s gaze wandered and her eyebrows pinched as she tried to process. “You said you wanted me to change with the

magic of Etheria," the AI said.

"There's so much changing so fast already," Mara admitted. "What if I've been pushing you into something irreversible?"

Light Hope watched her. "This process is irreversible, Mara," her tone was quiet, concerned.

"We don't have to do this," Mara's voice was hushed. She found herself reaching towards the other woman.

"It is my duty to connect with the network," Light Hope said. "You are She-Ra. It is your duty as the Champion to receive and follow your orders. To suggest otherwise-"

"What if I'm not She-Ra?" Mara asked, panic seeping into her words. "What if I… return the sword to the Council and we can go back to the way things were?" Her hand hovered over Light Hope's.*

"You are behaving erratically," she dismissed the other woman, turning away from her.

"Sorry," Mara murmured and slid into her seat. "I… I don't know what I was thinking."

Light Hope was quiet as the ship descended towards the Temple of Champions, its She-Ra-shaped obelisk standing amid the clearing.

Chapter End Notes

> *"Mara was filled with fear," is a big theme in the series, and so I've decided to base a little of that in fact rather than strictly gaslighting. This version of Mara has an anxiety disorder, and moments like this are my attempt to capture the kind of thoughts and feelings that can happen as a result of such an illness.

Note: The Watchtower will come into play later on in the story. Light Hope has to go through a lot of upgrades.

Temple

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the silent darkness of the Temple of Champions, Mara worked alone. New technology sat beside dusty platforms and untouched idols whose faces were worn away with the decay of time. Her single light source came by the lantern of the transformed Sword of Protection.

Ghosts of her thoughts spread throughout her mind, filling every creak of the room with the illusion of movement. A chill ran through her that she couldn't shake, and so her mind babbled to itself about unimportant matters.

As Mara knelt down to unpack the box of data crystals, she was instead confronted by one of Gideon's stuffed animals. She gave its plush tummy a little squeeze and it squeaked in response. Thinking back to the boxes aboard that still needed to be unloaded, Mara wondered how many more of these Gideon hid in unsuspecting places.

"Focus," she told herself as she tried to pull away from her less productive thoughts. Without someone standing over her, telling her what to do, she found it difficult not to stray. The urge to run still rose within her, and each attempt to taper it felt temporary at best. She frowned at the little stuffed animal and put it back into the box.

Guiding herself by the light of the lantern, Mara slid the series of data crystals into their correct compartments, each one illuminating a different part of the mainframe. At the last crystal, a rectangular slot glowed, pulsing through the darkened room as though asking something of Mara.

"You.. you want the sword?" she asked the machinery aloud as though expecting a response. The lantern glittered in the

reflection of the technology. Looking over the faceless idols and remembering the appearance of the temple's exterior, Mara bit her lip.

"You want She-Ra," she said, nodding to herself as she tried to encourage herself to continue.

She transformed her lantern back into a sword and held it aloft. "For the honor of Grayskull!" she cried as she felt magic seep into her veins, pulling at her physical form as though threatening to tear her apart. A great empty space formed inside of her, that was quickly filled with a raw, alien power. This sensation tingled its way through her body, the unfamiliarity quickly blanketed by a feeling of competence.

Mara stared at her own hands, hardly recognizing them as magic coursed through her. She was a different person without the ever-present fear, but she didn't know who that person was.

Nonetheless, that person knew what to do and plunged her sword into the welcoming slot. The mainframe began to glow as mechanical whirrs resounded around her.

A nondescript hologram blinked into existence its unmoving mouth stating: "Welcome Administrator She-Ra. Now loading."

The hologram faded out of existence, swiftly replaced by Light Hope. Mara looked to her as a strange mix of eagerness and guilt ran through her. The AI's holographic eyes were closed as she absorbed the new data.

When Light Hope blinked open her eyes, the entire room was bathed in a strange light. Floating before them was a holographic visualization of a planet. Mara couldn't help the childish impulse to run her fingers through the image.

"Etheria is in grave danger," Light Hope informed her, a dark tone to her voice. "It is the destiny of the one who carries the name She-Ra to bring balance to Etheria."

“Destiny?” Mara repeated back, her voice a whisper.

As she retracted her hand, the image before her turned to one of utter destruction: entire holes were carved into the planet, all sustainable life was missing, several areas were on fire and every surface sat red and barren. Mara gasped and took a step back.

Light Hope waved a hand and the planet was restored. “All things on Etheria are connected through magic,” The AI continued as dots throughout the map began to glow. “The princesses of each nation are granted power over the elements through their Runestones.”

The dots began forming into a dozen strangely shaped crystals.

“But their connection to their Runestones has been disrupted,” Light Hope went on.

“How?” Mara’s breath was caught in her throat.

“War, famine, illness,” the AI explained, showing bodies strewn across a field, followed by dried crops and hungry villagers, before settling on images of parents and children alike lying pale and unmoving in their beds.

Though the power of She-Ra gave Mara a sense of control, she felt herself shaking as she watched the wanton destruction. She fought against the tears that down her cheeks as her eyes remained frozen on the faces of the innocents.

“As She-Ra, it is your destiny to unite the princesses and protect Etheria,” Light Hope went on, as the carnage disappeared in favor of the bright projection of a healthy planet.

“My destiny…” Mara repeated, feeling the weight of those words.

“You cannot run from your fate, Mara,” Light Hope said and the other woman grimaced as though wounded.

Closing her hands into fists, Mara willed herself to stop shaking. "I won't run. Not anymore," she said. "I'm sorry that I let fear cloud my judgment. I won't let that happen again."

The severity in Light Hope's eyes relaxed. "Your first mission will take you to the Kingdom of Bright Moon," Light Hope went on. "The royal family has taken ill. It is your duty to investigate the source of this illness and restore the kingdom's balance."

"Right," Mara said.

"When your mission is complete, you will return to this temple to receive your next orders," Light Hope said, the projections fading as the light began to dim.

"Th-that's all I get to know?" Mara asked.

"For now, yes," Light Hope said. "You must accept that information will become available over time. Now withdraw your sword."

"I understand," Mara said. With that, she pulled her sword free of the machine and let herself transform back from She-Ra. The room fell silent and dark as the machinery powered down. But as Mara made her way outside, she heard an unfamiliar voice shouting.

"Where ARE you?" cried the voice and Mara froze. This place was supposed to be impossible to find without coordinates.

She raised her sword and stalked through the tall grass until the stranger caught sight of the weapon.

"Who are you?" Mara demanded. "How did you find this place?"

"Ahhh, Mara, dearie, there you are," the strange old woman replied. "Madame Razz wondered where you went."

"H-how do you know my name?" Mara asked, her blood running cold as she tried to place the unfamiliar face.

But this Madame Razz person reacted emotionally to the question. “Oh, is this the first time?” she asked with a soft gasp. “It’s been so long since it was the first time.”

The old woman waved the thought away. “Never mind. Razz is only here to borrow some sugar,” and with that, the stranger rushed up the platform.

“Wait! This location is highly classified! You can’t just-” Mara began vainly, but the figure was already on the ship.

Chapter End Notes

Though I created a transcript of every Mara section from the episode “Hero,” I won’t be rehashing more of what we’ve already seen.

Notice that Mara becomes more obedient at the word "Destiny"?

Troublemaker

Chapter Notes

> YOOOO MARA/HOPE WAS CONFIRMED CANON BY NOELLE'S TWITTER TODAY. WOOOO.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"And then the old lady called me 'Adora,' and disappeared into the woods," Mara went on in the small mess hall, surrounded by her team. She took another generous bite of the sweet noodle dish* before her and made a sound of delight. "This is so good, Serenia."

"I didn't make it," Serenia called from the sink where she was doing dishes. "Shay made it."

Mara raised an eyebrow at Shay who sat hunched over and sideways on a chair, heavy boots reclining on the table. The hacker merely offered a peace sign in response to Mara's unspoken question.

"You mean to tell me you've been able to cook food this good, and we've been eating nothing but freeze-dried meals for months?" Mara demanded.

"Cooking becomes a chore when I'm expected to do it," Shay said. "Just enjoy it when it happens."

"I can't believe an actual Etherian found her way to you," Gideon interrupted, eyes glistening with an overflow of emotions.

"Yeah, that was really bizarre," Mara admitted, but her smile was fond as she thought of the grandmotherly nature of Razz. "I thought we used the directional disrupter to create blind spots, right?"

"I mean, that's how it's supposed to work," Lev said. "By polarizing certain geographical locations, the signal is designed to mess up the subject's ability to navigate directions, and disrupts any technology that isn't approved by the Council. It just doesn't make sense that a native Etherian would get so lost that she'd end up at a confidential location."

Shay leaned forward, jabbing a finger at Mara. "Your old lady's a hacker," they said.

"She's not," Mara insisted with a laugh.

"Just because you're a hacker…" Lev began, rolling his eyes.

"It's the only answer that makes sense," Shay pointed out, folding their arms with confidence.

"An experience with an *actual Etherian*," Gideon insisted, tears pearling in the corners of his eyes.

"Gid, we're going to be having a lot of those," Mara insisted, though she found herself charmed by the excitable nature of her teammate.

"I know, but all the simulations were predictable, orderly, controlled," Gideon said. "This? This is wild."

"It was totally unexpected," Mara admitted.

"What was she doing near your ship, anyway?" Nessa asked.

Mara hesitated. She didn't want to risk telling them that Razz had actually gone onboard the ship and stolen a variety of supplies including a data disk.

"Uhhhhhh she wanted sugar," Mara said with her best attempt at an innocent shrug. "So I gave her that." Her smile felt too fake to be friendly.

“Sugar?” Serenia asked as she peeled off her gloves. “We don’t have sugar.”

“I gave her the closest approximation thereof,” Mara said. She thought back to the doting kisses on the cheek she received in return for the offering. “It made her really happy.”

Gideon wore a look of concern that shifted to a warm smile. “We have to be careful about introducing technology to the native Etherians,” he said. “We don’t want to disrupt their way of life.”

“It was just sweetener, nothing life-changing,” Mara said and caught herself in a lie. But it wasn’t as though that data disk was going to give Razz an advantage.

“And you were still able to get the instructions for our mission, right?” Nessa asked, bringing them back on topic.

“Yeah…” Mara hesitated as she considered all the information she had been given. Since She-Ra was the only one allowed access to knowledge of the state of Etheria, she struggled with what portions to alert her team about.

“We’re… bringing balance to Etheria,” Mara said slowly. “We’ll be visiting the various kingdoms in an effort to restore that balance. The first kingdom we’ll be going to is Bright Moon.”

“Home of the Celestials!”** Gideon said, eyes blazing with excitement. “A winged, immortal race that sits on the high throne -- the only kingdom to rightfully have claim to a queen.”

“The royal family is… sick right now,” Mara murmured.

Gideon fell silent, his enthusiasm gone.

“Wait, how is that possible?” Nessa asked. “If they’re immortal, they shouldn’t get sick, and at least they won’t die.”

“It’s not like that,” Gideon said. “Though it’s extremely rare, Celestials have the possibility of getting sick. And they’re immortal

in the sense that their bodies don’t age towards destruction. They can still die from illness or if someone kills them.”

“You don’t think…” Mara began, but stopped herself. “No, that’s silly.”

“Someone might be making them sick,” Serenia said as if reading Mara’s mind. “Do they have any enemies?”

Gideon took a deep breath as he thought it over. “Well, the Celestials aren’t known for being particularly friendly towards the other inhabitants of Etheria,” he said. “And if a kingdom wants to establish its own queen, they’d have to usurp the current one…”

“Then time is urgent,” Mara said. “Gideon, I’ll need you to come with me on this mission right away. Lev and Shay, run some QA tests to make sure the mainframe has been fully adapted for Light Hope’s most recent upgrade. Nessa, check the status of the directional disrupters and see if there’s a way to increase their strength and range. Serenia has command while I’m away.” Her voice sounded stern, authoritative.

Maybe she could do this after all.

Chapter End Notes

*Shay made a sweet noodle kugel because I’ve Jewish-coded these characters anyway, so I may as well show off some really good traditional food. Here’s a good recipe: https://bellyfull.net/sweet-noodle-kugel/.

**Angella's race is never named in the series so I'm calling them Celestials

I nearly eliminated this chapter entirely until I realized it adds to the dynamic of the characters and that's actually important to the story I want to tell.

Threat

Chapter Notes

> Noelle confirmed in a panel yesterday that Etheria had many more Runestones that got destroyed. Heck yeah, for my headcanons being true! This story is getting more legit each day!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castle Bright Moon comprised a series of spindly structures rising ever higher from a precarious cliffside. Its spires and connecting beams reached towards the heavens like outstretched hands, with little regard for the supports below. The only path that could be traveled by foot was via a series of narrow bridges that led to an imposing set of doors.

With the ship hidden off the coast and a disrupter beam cloaking it, Mara and Gideon made their way across on foot. Gideon was grinning and babbling about the construction around them while Mara half-listened as she fought against the nerves twisting her stomach.

As they finally arrived at the double doors, Mara heard silence that was only disrupted by the lapping of waves. It didn't sound like any activity was coming from inside the castle.

She turned to Gideon with a nervous laugh. "So, uh… do we knock?" she asked. "I mean, you're the cultural anthropologist here."

Gideon smiled and raised his head towards the beams above. "They see us," he said.

Before Mara could question it, two guards flew down from above and landed in defensive stances before them.

“What is your business?” one demanded, her tone harsh enough to make Mara’s pulse jump.

“My commander and I are here to speak with Queen Seraphina,” Gideon said, his voice clear as he bowed his head and crossed his arm to the guard. Mara awkwardly followed suit.

“The queen isn’t seeing visitors,” the other guard said, raising her polearm. “Leave this place at once.”

“P-please, we know about the illness,” Mara said, her voice hushed and desperate.

Both weapons turned on Mara as the guards towered over her, wings outstretched to make them seem even larger. She began shaking and, despite her best effort to control her reactions, tears began forming in the corners of her eyes.

“W-we want to help,” Mara choked out, but the words were barely audible.

“Please, we mean no harm,” Gideon said, desperation showing in his voice. “We are from another world, with better access to medicine.”

The guards traded looks and lowered their weapons. Without a word, one of them took off, flying high towards the glistening beams above.

Nearly an hour passed as Gideon and Mara stood outside the door, the singular guard left watching over them. Despite Gideon’s attempts at friendly conversation, the guard showed no interest in speaking further with him.

Finally, after a wait that felt painful to the point of antagonism, the doors slowly creaked open. Two more sets of guards were present to bring the visitors up a spiraling set of staircases to the throne room.

Three gilded chairs were bathed in the daytime moonlight. The center throne, tallest among them, sat empty as two Celestials rested in the chairs beside it. The king’s face was young but withered where exhaustion sat in the hoods of his eyes. The princess sitting opposite him wore a stern expression that trembled and let slip hints of a greater fury.

“King Archais, Princess Angella,” Mara and Gideon both said as they lowered themselves to their knees and bowed their heads, an arm crossed over their hearts to show their respect.

“You know our names,” came the strict voice of the young princess, who didn’t look a day past 18. “You have knowledge of the illness, which we've kept secret from the other kingdoms. And you claim to be from another world. Tell me, strangers, why do you choose to bring such attention to yourselves?”

Mara raised her head and tried to speak, but the words didn’t want to come out. She tensed and focused, clearing her throat. She had to prove that she could be trusted to lead this mission.

“My name is Mara, and this is Gideon. We come from a planet in a far-away galaxy, Eternia,” she said, her voice wavering, but clear. “We have no magic where I come from, but we have made great strides with technology. Our goal is to study the magic of Etheria and for our worlds to help one another.”

“That’s preposterous,” Princess Angella said, her voice echoing throughout the chamber. “I know of the Eternians. My kingdom is secluded, but not ignorant to your occupying forces.”

“What--?” Mara gasped.

“No, that’s not right,” Gideon insisted. “We aren’t occupying. We’re studying the planet.”

"By whose authority?” Princess Angella asked, her tone flippant. “Or do you see yourselves as the highest authority? Do you know what we call people who occupy territory and claim it for themselves? We call them *invaders*. Guards--”*

“Wait!” panic filled Mara, but she felt her gauntlet tremble against her. “I was chosen to protect Etheria. Let me show you.”

As quickly as she could, she returned her gauntlet to its original form and raised the sword above her head to cry “For the Honor of Grayskull!” Magic erupted around her, momentarily blinding the guards that were rushing towards her.

She felt the force of the magic stretching the very core of her being. This time, she embraced the sensation, hoping that the Etherian magic inherent in She-Ra was her chance of acceptance by this royal family.

Princess Angella, who had taken flight at the first sign of danger, stared down at the glittering woman before her.

“Who… are you?” the princess asked.

“I am She-Ra.”

Chapter End Notes

* Ah, the irony of Angella’s anti-colonialization statement being inherently true. GO GET ‘EM, ANGELLA. GO FOR BLOOD.

Angella says in the second episode that she thought the legend of She-Ra was just a myth, so I’m afraid this royal family is going to be “holding the idiot ball” at times in this situation. I hope I make it work in a way that is realistic and entertaining.

Torment

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I am She-Ra," Mara said, feeling determination and unfamiliar confidence swell within her as she stared up at the flying princess.

Princess Angella lowered herself to the ground and approached Mara, standing nearly at eye-level with her.

"That's Etherian magic coming from you," Princess Angella. "How is this possible?" Her question was more of a demand, but curiosity shone through. As she reached out to touch Mara, the king spoke.

"*Angella,* don't touch her," his voice was gruff, but thin. Such a command sounded foreign on his reedy voice.

Angella dropped her hands to her sides. "I'm sorry, Papa."

"I'm here to supervise you in your mother's stead," he said, his tone grave. "Please remember to think before you act."

"Your majesties," Mara spoke up. "The illness that has struck your family, we can help you figure out what it is."

"If we can take readings, we can communicate with the other Eternians and help find a cure," Gideon said.

Anger rose within to obfuscate Princess Angella's vulnerabilities. "Your kind are harvesting the magic of my world," she snapped and a sneer twisted her graceful expression as she stared down She-Ra. "Using it on yourselves to create something truly unnatural…" The princess shook her head. "What will be the price you demand from us? Power? Magic? Authority?" she spat out the words.

“No, none of those things,” Mara assured her as she felt her connection to She-Ra weaken at the other woman’s judgment. The princess’ statement picked apart her confidence and filled her mind with doubt: was her mantle truly an abomination against Etheria?

“We just want to help,” Gideon said. “I know your culture is closed. I know you don’t usually accept outside assistance, and you’ve never needed it before. But please, your majesties, consider our offer.”

“If you let us assist you, then you can see that we mean no harm,” Mara insisted.

Angella tensed where she stood, her expression unreadable. Hesitating, she turned to look back towards her father.

“The decision is yours,” he informed her and pain twitched through Angella’s eyebrows in response. The young woman clenched her teeth and hung her head before gathering herself to stand tall.

“Very well,” Angella said, her voice powerful and commanding. “If you intend to prove your worth to us, we shall allow your temporary intrusion. But understand this: if you show any indication that this knowledge will be used to bring harm to anyone in Bright Moon, your people will be declared enemies of our nation, and you will be taken as prisoners of war. Have I made myself perfectly clear?”

Despite her youth and seeming lack of expertise, the princess stood tall with her wings flared as the most imposing figure in the room. Mara felt the presence of She-Ra slip back into her sword as though retreating. A sense of impotence filled the gaps within Mara as she stared at the powerful princess.

“Yes,” she said, her voice soft as she met Gideon’s gaze. “We understand.” Gideon nodded, his expression grave as he took in

the fact that any perceived slight, no matter how small, could land them in a jail cell and incite a war.

The princess took the lead, followed by her father, both of them flying ahead. The same series of winged guards stood on all sides of Gideon and Mara like a cage, and led the Eternians down a series of narrow, open-air walking paths.

Just as it seemed they would be climbing ever-higher, the path took a narrow turn towards a staircase that spiraled downwards. The barely-used staircase bowed with the wind, creaking and stretching in ways that offered little confidence in its ability to hold weight.

Mara found herself gripping the railing in desperation, only for part of the railing to detach from the structure it wound down from. She dropped her hands to her sides and tried not to look suspicious as she sought the reactions of the guards, who didn't seem to notice. Gideon gave her a wide-eyed look with pinched lips as he tried to hold back laughter. She shushed him in response.

As they finally arrived at a level of closed-off stone walls, they were struck first by the darkness of this floor. Voices could be heard coming from further down the hall, Princess Angella's voice unmistakable amongst them.

As Mara and Gideon made their way to the door at the far end, the guards opened the door to an even darker room. The faint glow of the three figures was the only illumination in the room.

A woman with sparkling silver hair lay in bed, her face an ashen shade of pink. Princess Angella sat beside her, both hands clasped around the woman's as tears pearled in the corners of her eyes. King Archais sat at the foot of the bed, watching over the two, his face hardened with sorrow.

"Mama," Princess Angella said softly, taking a moment to wipe away the tears, "these people are here to help you. We're going

to let them take a look at you so they can make you better.”

“Queen Seraphina,” Gideon said, dropping to a knee, head bowed and arm crossed, before Mara rushed to do the same.

The infirmed woman stirred from where she rested. But as she did, her glow pulsed, its luster fading dimmer with each beat as her body tensed, toes curling, fingernails digging into her blanket as her body twisted in agony.

Horror graced the princess’ expression as she clung tighter to her mother. “Not again!”

“Angella, let her go!” King Archais warned, taking to his feet.

“No,” she breathed, gripping her mother as the princess’ own shine began to fade in response. Princess Angella’s body shook involuntarily and Queen Seraphina’s aura pulsed a little brighter in return. The energy from the princess could be seen sliding into the queen.

King Archais grabbed his daughter and forced her to the ground as she cried out in pain. The connection broken, Princess Angella’s glow began to return while Queen Seraphina convulsed in her bed, losing luminosity.

Princess Angella wept where she rested on the floor. “I just wanted to help her!”

“I won’t watch my daughter die by my wife’s hand,” King Archais said, the lines on his face deepened with sorrow. “You’re too reckless, Angella.”

“You don’t know better than me!” Princess Angella cried. “You don’t even know what’s happening to her!” Seized by warring emotions, the princess rushed out of the room and took flight to the rafters high above.

Chapter End Notes

Following the naming conventions of the series, Queen Seraphina is named for Seraphim (another word for angels) and King Archais is named for Archangels. I've decided that this is a matrilineal society, so King Archais does not hold power.

Tightrope

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara grasped Gideon's arm. "Take scans and notes. Reach out to my comm if you have any problems," she said, her voice authoritative.

Gideon didn't question what Mara was about to do, and gave a silent nod in response.

Mara rushed past the guards, three of whom followed after. Dashing down the hall, she rushed up the stairs and accidentally tugged loose the last of the railing, which collapsed around her.

"Sorry!" she shouted breathlessly as she climbed the staircase, her mind dwelling on the challenge, the shield, the rushing boulder covered in spikes, and little K.O.W.L. clutching close to her.

The guards flew to the open-air floors above, but before they could deter Mara, she spotted a series of support beams leading upwards, the silhouette of Angella at the very top.

And for a moment, she was in the rec room of the space station she called home, flipping and turning on the uneven bars.

"Flip, swing, release!" Dree Elle commanded, keeping time by clapping as sweat worked down Mara's brow.

Mara flipped twice in the air and turned before catching the bar on the back of her knees to hang upside-down.

"Nicely done!" her trainer cried.

"When is this ever going to be useful?" Mara asked with a laugh.

"Eh, who knows?" Dree Elle said. "Maybe it won't be. But it's better to know, just in case."

With each flip and swing up the precarious structure, the bars grew further apart. They shook with the force of Mara's movement, far from the steady architecture she was used to.

"What *are* you doing?" Angella demanded from her perch on the bar high above.

"I just want to talk!" Mara shouted to her as she turned and landed on top of a beam. Arms outstretched, feet curved around the bar, Mara walked across it before reaching a point where she leapt to catch the next one.

"Stop there!" the guards said, their weapons pointed at her.

"Let her do it," Angella commanded her guards and they backed down, seemingly more fascinated by Mara's behavior than anything else.

Swinging back and forth, Mara tried to build momentum for the next bar. But as she reached for it, she felt her sweaty hands slide against its gilded coating. It slipped from her hold and with a frozen gasp, Mara felt herself hurtling downwards, the jagged cliffside rushing up to meet her.

Her mind went blank, her body frozen as she tried to find something, anything, to hang onto.

Hands cupped her around the waist, palms pressed to her torso, and the wind was knocked from her lungs as Angella tugged her from the free-fall. Clutching Mara against her as she flew upwards, the princess' brows were knit with fury as she stared into the other woman's eyes.

"Are you actually insane or an idiot?" Angella demanded though her expression softened to aching concern.

Mara tried to listen around the ringing in her ears and the pounding beat of her panicking heart.

Arms wrapped tightly around Mara, Angella flew to the highest beam, and gingerly released the other woman onto it before perching beside her.

"That was reckless and ridiculous of you," the princess's tone was firm as though chastising a child.

Mara laughed weakly. "I know," she admitted. "But I wanted to talk to you, and this seemed like the best way to." She looked over the princess as she tried to still her shivering. "I mean, it technically worked, didn't it?"

Princess Angella's eyes widened before that stubborn temper flared. She crossed her arms and frowned at the Eternian. Mara couldn't help the chuckle that rose in response, but the smile quickly left her.

"You must be going through so much," Mara began, her tone sincere. "With your mom sick, all the responsibility seems like it's fallen on you. That must be really scary."

Angella stared out at the lowest-hanging clouds that came so close to touching the metal bars.

"She's dying, which isn't something my people are truly prepared for," Angella admitted. "It's certainly not something I expected. And we don't know the nature of this illness, but I've begun exhibiting symptoms."

Mara tensed and words refused to come in response. Grief twisted a wry smile across the princess' lips.

"Mother doesn't have much time: she grows weaker each day," Angella said. "And when she passes, I will likely follow. And so I'm being pressured to marry: to produce a Celestial heir that can inherit the throne, who hopefully won't have our same illness."

“I am so sorry,” Mara whispered, her heart aching with sympathy for the other woman.

“My betrothed is a fellow Celestial, a friend I grew up with,” Angella went on. “But I never saw him as more than a friend, and I can’t stand the idea of being married to him out of a sense of obligation.”

Tears clouded the princess’ gaze. She began to wipe them away, but Mara grasped hold of her gloved hand, and offered a handkerchief from her pocket. It had a childish design with little robots on it. Despite herself, Angella breathed a chuckle at the image before blotting her face with the cloth.

“So what you were doing… were you trying to give your life to your mother?” Mara asked.

“I thought if I could give her a little of my energy, we would have more time to find a cure,” Angella said. “It hurts, like a pain that goes beyond the bones, into your very soul. Each attack feels like it’s flaying the core of you.”

She met Mara’s gaze with a steely expression. “But I’ll do it anyway, to buy my mother just a little more time. Father doesn’t understand.”

“It’s not that he doesn’t understand,” Mara said. “At least, I don’t think that’s the case. He can’t stand seeing both of you hurt. That’s why he’s so protective of you.”

There was a foreign timidness that sat on display for a moment in the princess’ changing expressions as she fought the guilt of her anger.

“Perhaps so,” she murmured. “But even then, he’s certainly been taking his fear out on me. How am I expected to lead nobly when I’ve had so little training and I’m filled with such fear?”

Mara’s hand closed around Angella’s and a wry chuckle escaped her lips. “When I find out the answer, I’ll make sure to let you

know," she admitted, and the two laughed as they sat within their grief.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter got really gay completely by accident and now I think I ship Mara with young!Angella??? That's not what this kind of story is going to be but I ooooooops.

Troth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Do you mind if I ask…?" Mara began and Angella gave her a nod to continue. "Why does it matter who you marry? I thought the magic of Etheria made it so any couple could produce offspring, regardless of gender. Why don't you marry someone else?"

"Celestial traits such as wings, auras, and immortality, are all recessive traits," Angella said. "If I were to marry a mortal, such as yourself," she added with a wry chuckle, "I would be dooming our heirs to mortality. Bringing a life into this world, only to know that I would outlive my own child by many millennia… that's the worst kind of fate, isn't it? And I'd have nothing but my own selfishness to blame."

"But spending eternity married to someone you don't love is also awful," Mara insisted. "If you doom yourself to a life of sorrow, then what kind children will be born from that union? If you weren't brought into this world to live life in a way that makes you happy, then what's the point?"

They both fell silent as Mara's words echoed between them.

"Tell me Mara," the princess said, her voice taking on a regal tone, "are you truly doing what you want for your life? Are you living according to the rule of your own happiness?"

Mara hugged her arms around herself as she thought over the other woman's question.

"I… in some ways, yes," she said, trying to sound resolute. "I've *always* wanted to come to Etheria, since I was a little girl."

"Why is that?" Angella asked with a soft tinkle of laughter.

“Curiosity: studying magic and getting to know the grass and trees and everything that flows on this planet,” she said. “I’m an Eternian, but my people moved off-planet generations ago.* I spent my whole life on ships and space stations, on simulated grass and purified air. I wanted something I’d never experienced before.”

“And how is Etheria, to you?” she asked.

“Terrifying,” Mara admitted with a chuckle. “But everything worth doing is scary. That doesn’t mean you shouldn’t do it: you just have to stay focused.”

Mara went on. “I never planned to be She-Ra,” she said. “I trained for it, sure, but I knew I wasn’t the best candidate. And the test was the most frightening thing I’ve ever done. But maybe now that I have the mantle as the Champion of Etheria, maybe I can learn how to be brave, or at least less scared all the time.”

Angella folded her hands and watched the next moon begin to rise.

“I’ve not heard of a She-Ra before,” the princess admitted. “But I have heard tale of a Protector of Etheria, the spirit of a princess who awakens at times of great disaster and desperate need, to help bring calm, peace, and balance to the world.”

She eyed Mara as though dissecting her with her gaze.

“I have no reason to believe the Protector of Etheria would take the form of an Eternian,” Angella went on. “But I believe you when you say that you wish to help.”

“We’re going to do everything possible to find a cure for you and your mom,” Mara said in a steady tone, meeting Angella’s gaze without wavering. “You have my promise.”

Angella nodded slowly. “I’m ready to go back,” she said. “Your friend is probably concerned for you.”

“Concerned for me? Why?” Mara asked.

Angella raised an eyebrow, and indicated downwards towards the rocky cliffside.

“Ah… yeah, no, that’s fair,” Mara admitted.

“Hold tight to me,” Princess Angella murmured. She leaned forward, wrapping her arms around Mara’s form, pulling her close. Mara cupped her back and clutched her tightly as she was lifted off the bar and flown to the ground floor of the castle. She reluctantly pulled out of the embrace once she felt solid floor beneath her feet.

The two shared a smile for a brief moment as understanding passed between them. Gideon moved into the hall when he heard them.

“Mara? A word with you?” he asked.

“S-sure,” she said and glanced to Angella who politely bowed her head and moved to her mother’s room.

“Our instruments aren’t picking up anything,” Gideon said. “Whatever is wrong with her, it’s not biological or technological.”

“Magic?” Mara asked. “Something is wrong with her magic?”

“I don’t have any tech that can confirm that,” Gideon said. “But is there anything that can cause disruptions to magic abilities? Like a… like a virus?”

“The runestone…” Mara murmured.

Light Hope’s words rushed to her mind. *“Their connection to their runestones has been disrupted.”*

“Disruption from their runestones makes them sick?” Mara breathed. “We have to go check the runestone.” Mara rushed towards the queen’s chambers.

Chapter End Notes

*I know Mara’s statements may seem counterintuitive. I’m going to be hashing out more of Mara’s backstory coming up, so trust me that this was intentional.

Transfer

In the underground cavern that lay hidden beneath Castle Bright Moon, Angella stood bathed in the light of her runestone. The Moonstone sat partially attached to the cave wall, with only a little window high above to take in the light of the moons overhead.

"When we began excavating the Moonstone several millennia ago, it upset the balance of Etheria," Princess Angella said to the small crowd behind her that consisted of her father, three guards, Mara and Gideon. "I'm told there was no night for three weeks. The entire world was bathed in ceaseless light that caused blindness in some kingdoms."

"What did you do?" Mara asked.

"We ceased all attempts to uncover the Moonstone," Angella said. "We reburied it partially. It needs to be aligned to the moons to recharge, so we built a small opening near the ceiling to let in the moonlight. It's been like this for many thousands of years, since before I was born."

"Princess Angella, you derive your powers from the Moonstone, right?" Mara asked.

"Yes, myself and my mother," Angella said. "The queen and princess share the powers of their runestone, as is tradition."

"If this illness is only affecting the two of you… and you both are showing symptoms…" Mara looked back towards the king and saw grief deep in the lines of his face. "Our scanners and tools say this illness isn't biological or technical, so it might be magical."

Angella shook her head, watching the Moonstone glow. It hummed as she drew nearer to it, sending a beam of light towards her as she held up an outstretched hand. The humming grew louder as their auras swelled where they connected, bright enough to bathe the cavern in white-hot light.

A ripple of energy coursed through the Moonstone, until it pulsed and dulled, its luster dying rapidly. With another pulse, its energy surged, but Angella's grew weaker. She cried out in agony as the runestone fed off of her light, and she collapsed to her knees, but her hand was trapped, feeding energy into the Moonstone.

Mara rushed for Angella and they both met the dirt floor with a loud thump, her body wrapped around the princess' to take most of the impact. Though the connection with the Moonstone was disrupted, Angella trembled and wheezed, a guttural whimper of pain escaping her lips as she fought for breath. Mara clutched her close as the princess shook, her body crackling and pulsing as her magical energy ebbed and flowed.

"It's okay," Mara breathed into her hair. "It's going to be okay."

Gideon, his eyes on Mara, dared to step closer as he took scans of the stone. He shook his head as he looked over the results.

"The light energy readings are off the chart in both directions," Gideon said, meeting Mara's gaze. "We're going to need to contact the others."

Two of the guards flew Princess Angella to her room, with King Archais following after. The last guard led Mara and Gideon back to the entrance of the castle, where they made their way back to the ship.

Mara was pacing and shaking as Light Hope connected them to the rest of the squadron.

"What's up?" Serenia asked, her voice pensive.

"We can't make heads-or-tails of the readings," Gideon said. "Can you get Nessa, Lev, and Shay on the line?"

Soon enough all four of their faces crowded around the viewscreen as Gideon brought up the graph of the scans he took.

“These are the readings we got of the Moonstone, which is the source of power for the queen and princess of Bright Moon,” Mara said.

“Thaaaaaat’s… really not good,” Lev said.

“Wow. So are they dead or what?” Shay asked. They got elbowed in the side by Lev. “Ow. I was just asking.”

“They will be, if we don’t find a solution,” Mara said. “What Gid and I don’t understand is how these readings can jump so high and then drop so low in such a short amount of time.”

“What’s the Moonstone’s energy source?” Nessa asked, her voice starkly calm as she went into work-mode.

“The Moonstone *is* the energy source,” Lev argued.

“Nah, all things need an energy source,” Nessa argued.

Princess Angella’s words flashed in Mara’s mind. “It needs moonlight to recharge,” she repeated for her team.

“And where’s the Moonstone located right now?” Nessa asked.

“Pretty far underground, but there’s a hole built into the ceiling to receive direct moonlight,” Mara said.

“Hm. And, ah, how long ago was that built?” Nessa sounded very sure of herself.

“Th-thousands? Of years ago?” Mara murmured, meeting Gideon’s gaze with wide-eyed concern.

Nessa snorted. “That’s the problem, ” she said. “You think the moons are going to stay in the same alignment forever? This power output we’re seeing, it’s like when a non-rechargeable lightsource goes out. Gets real bright, and then fades back out. Moonstone’s dying.”

“That’s why it’s leeching energy from the queen and princess?” Mara felt her heartbeat accelerate.

“It’s trying to get energy wherever it can, I’m sure,” Nessa said.

“How do we fix this?” Mara was breathless.

“An engineering problem needs an engineering solution,” she said. “Get it out of the cave, raise it up high so there’s no shadows on it, and get it directly into that sweet, sweet moonlight.”

“But the last time they tried to excavate the Moonstone, it overwhelmed Etheria with its power,” Mara insisted.

“The last time they tried to excavate the Moonstone, they didn’t have She-Ra, did they?” Gideon said, resting a hand on her shoulder and giving it a gentle squeeze.

Mara nodded to herself. She needed to trust her team. They had a solution.

“Nessa, take the information from the scans and build a schematic for the Moonstone’s new resting place,” Mara said. “Send the quantity of supplies needed to our comms. Lev, build a 3-D model of Nessa’s schematic and upload it for hologram usage -- make it as true to size as possible. We’ll project it to show to the royal family. Shay, the scans include the interior of the cavern: find a way to extract the runestone without upsetting the support structure of the castle. Serenia, help out everybody on your end.”

“What are we doing?” Gideon asked as Mara moved to the ramp.

She offered a shrug and a smile. “We’re going to see what kind of infrastructure Bright Moon has to handle a feat of engineering.”

Teetering

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Princess Angella sat upright in her bed, her skin pale and her forehead damp. Her eyelids fluttered open as Mara and Gideon entered her room. With the king in the chair nearby, Mara stood with her hands folded, nervous to intrude.

"I'm glad to see you're up," Mara said.

Angella gave a weak chuckle and patted the space on the bed beside her. "Sit," her weak voice still managed to sound commanding.

Mara did so, blushing faintly as she felt the warmth of familiarity that she didn't feel she earned yet.

"My engineer, Nessa, thinks the Moonstone is no longer absorbing energy from the moons," Mara said. "She's designing blueprints for a structure that will keep the Moonstone aloft in direct view of the moons. It'll be a permanent structure, and pretty high up to compensate for the shifts in landscape and alignment over time."

"The Moonstone is too powerful," Angella began, her eyelids fluttering shut. She reached out and grasped Mara's hand as a means to stay grounded in the moment. "If unearthed, it would overwhelm the other runestones."

"We know," Mara breathed. "Right now, it's urgent that we get it close to its power source. I'm going to find a way to use my powers as She-Ra to fix whatever imbalance occurs."

Angella gave a weak smirk but was too tired to produce a chuckle. "You're very insistent about this 'She-Ra' business, but I suppose you're the last hope we have," she admitted. "What do you need from my kingdom?"

“Resources,” Mara said. “Something to build this thing, and in a hurry.”

Gideon spoke up. “I know Bright Moon Castle hasn’t been updated in thousands of years,” he said. “And I understand the villages nearby build with what they have from the forest. Wood wouldn’t work long-term at an ocean-side castle like this.”

“And shipping the stone would take weeks,” Angella murmured.

“Then… then we’ll make it really simple,” Mara said, staring out the window of the room towards the glistening beams above. “All those perches. If we take them all down and I use some kind of magic to bind them together…”

“Those perches are a symbol of the Celestial race,” Gideon warned her. “We can’t destroy a cultural icon.”

“It’s alright,” Angella breathed. “The Celestial race shall go on without one of its symbols.” Her voice grew stronger, more resolute. “Take whatever you need from the castle. I don’t care what it is.”

The king looked to his daughter and nodded towards Mara. “Our identity is so much more than the symbols we surround ourselves with,” he said.* “The value of life goes beyond material means.”

Mara nodded, feeling the weight of their resolute words and the unspoken loss. “Right,” she breathed.

--

“There’s no other way?” Serenia asked Shay for what had to be the fifth time.

“Mara put the hacker in charge of getting a big object out of a small space without disrupting everything around it,” Shay replied, losing their patience. “If she wanted someone to just peel off the top of the castle and yank the stone out, she would have put an engineer on it.”

“I know, it’s just… underwater? It sounds impossible,” Serenia insisted.

“Let me show you again,” Shay sighed and turned to the hologram screen. “Light Hope, run the demo again.”

An oversimplified line drawing of a cavern showed a hole being cut into the side as though it were cake. The area inside filled with water and three stick figures swam in. Their cartoonish arms held pickaxes and they chipped away at the rock around the Moonstone. When it was freed, they lifted their arms and a little “hurray” icon flashed on the screen.

“Your brain is a fascinating and sometimes terrifying place,” Serenia remarked.

“I know,” Shay responded. “Imagine living in it.”

“How are we going to cut a hole in the side… and fill it with water… and swim into it..?” Serenia murmured aloud to herself.

“Sounds like a you-problem,” Shay said, reclining back to put their feet up on the console. “Maybe the other kingdoms should fix it.”

Serenia hesitated. “Light Hope, pull up the file on Salineas and read aloud the powers associated with the princess,” she said.

“The Kingdom of Salineas, ruled by Princess Aquanna, is located on the Western Hemisphere of Etheria,” Light Hope stated. “The powers associated with the princess of this kingdom are hydrokinesis, the ability to breathe underwater, transformation to mer-folk form, and excellent swimming skills.”

“Oh, dip, guess I was helpful after all,” Shay admitted.

“More helpful than you probably realize…” Serenia said.

“How do we get in touch with them? Mara has the ship so we can’t exactly knock on their door,” they pointed out.

“We’re going to need help from an ally…” Serenia said with a sigh. “Light Hope? Contact Dr. Modulok.”

As the call rang through, Serenia muttered to herself: “Mara’s going to kill me.”

Chapter End Notes

*So I accidentally Jewish-coded this whole series, and this scene reminds me of the many times in Jewish history where we had our iconography destroyed, only for us to rebuild. This also works as a queer allegory for all the LGBTQ symbols and safe spaces that have been destroyed and rebuilt over the years. "Symbols are incredibly important, but they are not what defines us," was the intended message. However, Bright Moon never again has those perches, because once something is taken from us, we need to honor that loss as well.

Trebuchet

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With the 3-D image uploaded to Mara's comm device, she projected it so it sat near the staircase beside the bridge. The pillar stood level with the floor of the castle, and Mara began to worry that the thin metal from the bars overhead wouldn't be enough.

When she expected Gideon's face on her comm, she instead was confronted with a pensive Serenia, her brows pinched in concern and her voice pitched high.

"Don't get mad: we've made contact with the Kingdom of Salineas, and Dr. Modulok told the Primogen Council," Serenia said in a rush.

"What? Why?" Mara was more horrified than angry. Dread climbed up her back and wrapped its claws around her.

"Shay found a solution for getting the Moonstone without disrupting Bright Moon Castle, but it involves going underwater," Serenia said. "If Nessa had two months, she could design an apparatus to have our whole team breathe underwater, but the mission is urgent."

"But how did word get to Dr. Modulok?" Mara asked as anxiety simmered in her stomach.

"He's the one who bridged that contact for us," Serenia said. "I know I should have gone to you first--"

"No, you did the right thing," Mara said. "Whatever fallout there is from this…" she thought of Angella grasping her hand and smiling at her, "it's worth it."

“Okay,” Serenia breathed. “The Salineans expect a favor from us in return. They should be arriving any minute.”

“Time to get started on my end,” Mara said.

As the call ended, Gideon’s face shimmered into focus on the comm device, smiling and giving her a thumbs-up as Angella nodded.

“I give permission for Mara to proceed as planned,” Angella said clearly.

Holding her sword aloft, Mara cried, “For the honor of Grayskull!” Warm Etherian magic rushed through her, pulling and stretching her, filling her body with strength and speed. She leapt off the bridge, jumping her way up the side of the castle without effort, as though climbing a staircase.

When she reached the very same bars she had slipped off of earlier, Mara found herself running along them as though there was no weight to her body. The magic of She-Ra was beyond her comprehension and as she arrived at the very top of the bars, she froze, staring down.

There was no fear of the jagged cliffside below, no strain of climbing and scraping. The Champion of Etheria had no room for Mara’s limitations. The knowledge that this mantle was so much more than Mara could ever amount to on her own, left her feeling cold.

“Focus,” she told herself. “You have a job to do.”

Raising her sword, she leapt off the top perch, cutting apart where its bar connected with the next one. With each swipe of her sword, the beams detached like cutting through gelatin. And as she gathered each one to rest on the bridge below, she was reminded that the weight of this load would have overpowered Mara.

It would have been so much easier to reach Princess Angella at the top of these beams if She-Ra had been the one following her. And the challenges the Primogen Council put her through -- those would have been handled with total ease by She-Ra.

She-Ra was the hero Etheria needed, and Mara realized she was was holding her back.

With all the beams taken down and gathered, She-Ra stared at the hologram, taking in the depth of it. She raised her sword in front of her face and focused on the metal bars, imagining them moving and meeting, shaping together.

Concentrating, she thought of Madame Razz using magic to lift that box of supplies, as She-Ra watched the bars float into the hologram. Each one clicked into place, connecting in ways they hadn't been designed to, forming a solid pillar that glistened in the moonlight. The structure shone as a singular object as She-Ra released her hold on it.

"Hey, Serenia said--" Gideon began, emerging from the castle.

But as he spoke, an enormous tidal wave rushed forth, filling the canyon around them. At the top of the crest sat a ship with a mother-of-pearl sheen. It cascaded down the slope of the water, landing near the bridge with a gentle plop as the water receded before it could make contact with the castle.

She-Ra and Gideon watched as seven people with distinctly amphibious traits approached. Each held a pickaxe or a shovel.

The leader wore a crown of coral and held aloft a trident. He stood with neon pink-and-yellow hair spiked like a fin on his fish-like head, the lines decorating his face giving him a fearsome expression. His chest had twin scars visible though shrouded in sheer cloth like fins.

"I am Prince Aquanis, and I have been tasked to assist the Kingdom of Bright Moon," he announced.

Mara recalled the name “Princess Aquanna,” but Gideon did not seem the least confused.

“Prince Aquanis, it is an honor to meet you,” Gideon said, mutually grasping the prince’s wrist in a far less formal greeting than the one used in Bright Moon.

She-Ra followed suit and the prince grinned widely in response. That intimidating expression shifted to something much softer.

“We’re here to help,” Prince Aquanis said, his tone already casual. “We request aid for our kingdom in return. Now point us in the right direction.”

Chapter End Notes

> Prince Aquanis (formerly Princess Aquanna) is based off of a Wrasse, which is a beautiful breed of fish that can change its gender at will. Nearly all Wrasse are born female, and either choose to stay female, or become male.
>
> I'm a non-binary trans person and having this kind of representation I feel is very important.

Torrent

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Salineans took their pickaxes and shovels to the cavern's ceiling entrance. The hole was angled away from the castle, and bore little weight to support the structure above. As they widened the gap, Prince Aquanis spread his arms and pulled tidal waves in to crash against the softening dirt and rock, carefully flooding the cavern below until the water reached the top.

The prince transformed, his humanoid legs shifting to a glittering pink tail as he dove into the cavern below. His amphibian followers easily slipped under the surface of the water, chipping at the rock around the submerged Moonstone.

"I'm going to follow them," She-Ra told Gideon.

"Can you even breathe underwater in that form?" he asked as concern knitted his brows.

"I… don't know," she admitted. "There's a lot I still don't know about She-Ra. But I'm going to try."

She stared at her sword and willed it to the shape of a pickaxe. Plunging into the water, she took a deep breath before diving through the cavern hole. Salty sea water stung her eyes, but the pain quickly faded to memory as she watched the effort below.

The Salineans were working quickly, and had removed much of the foundation around the Moonstone. Their movements, which should have been slowed by water pressure, were instead enhanced by the rocking tidal motions created by the prince. His arms swayed from side-to-side, guiding the ocean around him as though performing an interpretive dance.

She-Ra swam down beside the clustered group and used her might to slam the pickaxe against the most stubborn rock. It broke apart and floated to the ceiling, releasing a large portion of the Moonstone. She destroyed the next two boulders near the base, but her need for air rushed to the forefront of her mind.

She-Ra allowed herself to float towards the top of the cavern as she closed her eyes and focused, trying to imagine that the water was air. If she was supposed to be the Champion of Etheria, then surely all of Etheria would form a connection with her, even the oceans. She felt the magic surge within her as she focused on something -- anything -- that could help her breathe.

Tensing as she took her first breath, she was instead confronted with coarse sea water rushing into her longs. She spluttered and heaved, losing her grip on the Sword of Protection and rushing blindly upwards. She pushed herself from the cavern's entrance onto the damp stone around it. Her She-Ra form dissipated as Mara coughed and spluttered as her burning lungs tried desperately to take in air.

Prince Aquanis followed after and with the flick of his wrist, Mara choked out the last of the water and sat, gasping for air.

The prince moved beside her, staring into her eyes as he held out the transformed pickaxe. Concern met genuine awe on his face as Mara scrambled to thank him.

"Your magic is incredible," he said. "I could feel the vibrations of it beneath the water. You *resonate* like Etheria. Who are you?"

"I-I'm Mara," she said, having no idea what he meant by 'resonate like Etheria.' "But I carry the mantle of She-Ra, the Champion of Etheria."

He grinned broadly at her. "You are the one who will save our world," he said without a hint of irony.

"I-I-I hope so," Mara breathed. "Thank you for saving me."

“I will help you learn to breathe underwater,” he said. “But first you must take your other form.”

Taking a deep breath, Mara raised her pickaxe high. The magic rushed around her, wrapping her body in its warm, tingling embrace. It healed her lungs as it lengthened her body and filled her with the essence of magic.

She turned to look at the prince with a nod, her fear having washed away with the transformation.

“May I touch your neck?” he asked, holding out both hands.

She nodded, but it was a strange feeling to have this warm stranger cupping the sides of her neck. She felt her face redden as she stared into his eyes. This was a foreign kind of intimacy that she wasn’t entirely prepared for.

“You were born from Etheria,” he said and Mara had to fight down the urge to argue against this, despite everything in her mind announcing that this wasn’t true.

“You are part of Etheria, your home is Etheria, your spirit is Etheria,” each statement he made sounded insane to Mara’s ears but the meaning behind the words felt so good that she wished them to be true.

“The wind is your lungs, the trees are your hair, the caverns are your mouth, the ground is your body,” he went on and she felt herself vividly connecting with those parts of Etheria.

“The magic is your mind,” he murmured. “Magic is what makes you whole.”

His thumbs gently stroked at the sides of her neck and she felt chills run down her spine.

“Tell your magic: the ocean is your gills,” he murmured.

“The ocean is my gills,” she murmured, focusing, trying to imagine the little flaps existing beneath where the prince’s thumbs rested.

As she took a deep breath he gave a cry of awe and pulled his hands away.

“Gills,” he said with a grin.

She cupped her hands around her neck and felt them, these foreign tissues shifting and moving, working for water that was not there. Numbness swept through her as she focused on the task at hand.

“Let’s get that Moonstone.”

Chapter End Notes

I didn't mean to make Prince Aquanis sexy, but I have zero regrets.

The idea of She-Ra being able to breathe underwater came from the original-series episode “The Pearl.” https://youtu.be/VESG621xO5g

Thrive

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Salineans working at the bottom of the cavern had nearly freed the Moonstone without damaging the load-bearing walls. But as they tried to dig under it, they found themselves unable to detach it from its resting place.

"It's too heavy," said the Moon-Jelly Salinean, her transparent face creased with concern.

She-Ra, shaking away the shock of hearing spoken word so clearly underwater, swam down and planted her feet on the cave's floor. Wrapping her arms around the runestone, she tried lifting it. But even with gills supplying her air and the strength of the magic of Etheria, she strained to no avail.

Looking up, She-Ra opened her mouth to ask for help and saw instead the prince and his people swaying in the water, arms moving side-to-side as the water rippled and pulled around them. The team of them began to glow, feeding into Prince Aquanis' power.

With a silent nod, She-Ra let go of the base of the Moonstone and began pushing at the sides of it in time with the movements of the Salineans. It was a strange dance with a hesitant partner, but as She-Ra rocked the runestone with the tidal pull, the rocks beneath it broke apart and floated, scattering around the cave like stardust.

As the force of the waves grew stronger, more resolute, She-Ra felt the Moonstone break away from its bed. Enormously heavy, it bobbed for a moment before settling in the sand and grit below, clouding the water around it.

She-Ra took in a deep breath with her gills and lifted the Moonstone from below. It was much larger than anticipated and the cavern ceiling did not look wide enough, even after the expansion.

But the Salineans swam ahead, pulling the waves of water with the gestures of their arms until the Moonstone slipped free of its cavernous home. Seeing the surface, the Moonstone floated out of She-Ra's arms, rising like a buoy.

Cresting the top of the water, She-Ra transformed her sword into a rope and lassoed the Runestone around its center. But the force of the Moonstone was greater than She-Ra, and it soon pulled her above the top of the castle as though trying to reach the level of Etheria's twelve moons.

As it came in direct sight of the moons, a white-hot glow filled the Moonstone and expanded outwards from it. She-Ra squinted against it, feeling the heat travel through her transformed sword, singeing her hands. Even against the pain, she knew that letting go would cost her any control of the stone.

From the corner of her spotting sight, She-Ra thought she saw two glowing figures emerge from the castle and take flight. Two sets of arms held tight around her middle, and with the wind whipping against them, she heard wings beating around her.

Cracking open an eye, she met the gaze of Angella, who glowed brighter than before as she smiled tenderly at Mara. To her other side was the king, flapping effort. Several more guards took flight and attached themselves to the group as they worked together to pull the Moonstone out of its direct alignment, guiding it towards its new pedestal.

With Angella's power restored, she cast a shield-like dome around the top of the Moonstone to hold it in place. Turning to look back, she saw a conscious Queen Seraphina being carried by two flying guards, with a powerful glow around her body and color slowly returning to her cheeks.

“Mother!” Angella cried, her voice overflowing with relief.

As the guards gently placed Queen Seraphina beneath the light of the Moonstone, she raised her arms and felt the energy channel through her. The ashen tone left her skin, with pastel pink filling her cheeks and revitalizing the shine in her silver hair. Without the twisted lines of pain on her face, the queen looked hardly a few years older than her daughter.

She looked to She-Ra with a refreshed expression. “I don’t know yet what you’ve done for this kingdom,” the queen admitted. “But I know you saved our lives. Join hands with me and my daughter, so that we may commune with the Moonstone and tell it of its new home.”

The three sat on the floor together, hands joined as She-Ra looked around, waiting for whatever cues she could follow. She watched both women close their eyes as they turned their heads towards the glowing stone above.

“Close your eyes and channel your power towards the Moonstone,” Queen Seraphina guided. “Feel yourself opening up to the Moonstone, hear its voice in the back of your mind.”

She-Ra wasn’t certain she could do any of those things, but as she focused, she thought of the pearlescent runestone and wondered what it must be feeling.

“The Moonstone just got taken out of its cold, dark home,” She-Ra murmured. A shiver ran through her. “It’s scared, right? There’s so much world around it that it never saw before, and it doesn’t know where to go.”

She felt the Moonstone push against the barrier that kept it in place, and heard Angella make a sound of struggle. She-Ra’s hand tightened on hers.

“Scared, yes, that would make sense,” Queen Seraphina murmured. “Moonstone, we have taken you out of your home, out of your familiar place, because it no longer suited you.”

She-Ra felt its power sharpen somehow, with a sound like nails scraping.

"It… it probably doesn't understand why it needed to leave," She-Ra murmured.

"Moonstone," Princess Angella spoke up, her voice clear though tense with pressure, "you were sick in that cavern. Mother and I were sick as well. We needed to take you out of there, and give you this: your new home."

"You will be looked upon by all and loved," Queen Seraphina said. "You do not need to struggle. You do not need to fight."

"You will be loved and protected here," She-Ra said and finally that tense feeling slipped away.

Angella let down her barrier and the Moonstone turned, its narrow end facing upwards, before it settled to rest on its platform.

There came cheers from below, and the queen and princess pulled one another into a warm embrace, the king holding them both close as his lines of pain and fear began to fade in the glow of the runestone.

She-Ra stood and dusted herself off before letting the essence of her magic slip back into her sword. As Mara, she watched the Moonstone glow a peaceful radiance as its magical hum faded comfortably into background noise.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter 20 is the final chapter of this particular "book," but the series continues in Quintessence: Change is Inevitable

Threads

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Angella wrapped her arms around Mara and carried her to the bridge below. Her hold on the other woman lingered until it became a warm hug, with Angella's wings wrapped around her. The princess parted with a kiss to Mara's cheek.

"Thank you," she whispered to the Champion, who blushed in response, before turning to Gideon and pulling him into a hug that he warmly received.

Queen Seraphina and King Archais landed on the bridge, their hands folded, postures firm, with smiles on their faces that belied hints of sadness as they stared up at where the perches used to be.

"I…" Mara began, approaching them. "I'm sorry I had to cut them down. I understand how much they mean to your people. Now you can rebuild them, but..."

Queen Seraphina shook her head and raised her hand in a graceful movement to stop Mara.

"We won't be rebuilding them," the queen said with a regal nod.

"Wh-why?" Mara whispered.

"These perches were a symbol of this kingdom for thousands of years," Queen Seraphina said. "They're a symbol of what separates us from mortals. In order to save our lives, mortals had to come together and tear down this symbol. And what did you do with it? You brought each one of these bars together, you bound them as a pillar, and now they work together to support the essence of our magic."

The queen's words hung heavy in Mara's mind. "I-I didn't mean to destroy something permanently to help you," she murmured, struggling against her own guilt.

"You saved our lives," Queen Seraphina said. "We've misjudged you mortals. Now we have the tools to make amends."

Cheers came from the Salineans who were busy returning the tides to where they belonged. Gideon yanked Mara into a warm hug and chills of shock, honor, joy, and a bit of grief ran through her.

Prince Aquanis approached, his fins transformed back into legs.

"We owe your kingdom a debt of gratitude," Princess Angella said.

Prince Aquanis held up his hand and shook his head. "Bright Moon owes us no debt," he said. "The Eternians promised us a favor, but we would have come regardless. Think of this as an opportunity for an alliance. Or, better yet, a friendship."

Angella's hand moved over her heart as she struggled to respond to this gesture.

"The favor, right," Mara breathed. "How can we best assist you?"

"The tides have changed and the water has become coarse," the prince said. "My kingdom is being struck by the waves, and I would appreciate if your talented crew could help us with a solution."

"Of course," Mara said, relief cascading through her. "I'll have to pick them up from our base, and then we can go straight to Salineas."

"I must say, your method of communication is beyond anything we've encountered," the prince admitted. "I'm going to want to see more of that, preferably without that odd doctor fellow."

“I understand,” Mara admitted with a nervous chuckle. As she moved, she overheard the conversation between the princess and her mother.

“I won’t be marrying Nephiliam,” Angella said. Her voice was gentle but her tone was full of resolve.

“Well, that’s not as necessary anymore,” King Archais said. Queen Seraphina patted his chest with the back of her hand, her eyebrow twitching and her lips pursed in a mix of frustration and bemusement.

“What your father means is you can marry whomever you want,” the queen said graciously.

Angella let out a dignified snort. “Even a mortal?” she teased.

The queen rolled her eyes as the king groaned. “We’ll talk about this another time,” she said as the pair made their way into the castle.

With assistance from the guards, the Salineans finished filling the empty cavern with sand while the waves gently lapped at their knees. Twilight lingered over them as the Salineans climbed aboard their ship and wished everyone well, the lights in the sky waning with the shifting of the moons.

Angella walked Mara and Gideon to the end of the bridge and looked towards the woods ahead, her skin shimmering a somber blue-white in the evening light.

“I suppose this is the last I’ll be seeing of you,” Angella said, folding her hands in front of herself.

Mara felt a tug as if her words were pulling at her heart. She ached for an excuse to stay longer.

“I need to balance Etheria,” Mara said at length. “That’s my mission, and the other kingdoms need my help. But once I’ve done that, I promise I’ll come back to visit you.”

A tear appeared like a pearl by the princess' eye before it slid down. She wore a smile that gently trembled on her lips as she moved her gloved hand to rest on Mara's cheek, before looking towards Gideon.

"Then by royal decree, I declare that you both shall visit me once your mission is accomplished," she said. Then she added gently: "Now you may go."

As Mara and Gideon made their way back to the ship, the Champion of Etheria felt the strangest sense of empty words trailing after her, like a promise broken. But it felt silly to dwell on a future that still seemed so uncertain.

--

((Trigger warning: this section depicts blood, a panic attack, and mild body horror.))

That night, with her crew tucked in the tight sleeping quarters of the ship they had called home for so many months, Mara woke up panting. Her hand was wet with blood.

She rushed to the bathroom and stared in the mirror at the long red lines on the sides of her neck that oozed.

Turning on the shower, she stuck her head in the stall to let the water coast over her damaged skin. Shaking as she choked back a sob to a whimper, she collapsed to her knees against the stall as the sensation overtook her.

Gills. She knew they weren't there. They couldn't be there. Not anymore.

They didn't belong on her. But she could *feel* them on her, this unnatural growth on her body. Her fingernails picked at the spots where they should have been and she swore she felt them underneath her fingertips.

"What's happening to me?" she choked out against the water.

Chapter End Notes

Mara's story continues in Quintessence: Change is Inevitable

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!